Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Leviticus

Leviticus 1:1

- Then the LORD called to Moses and spoke to him from the Tent of Meeting: Leviticus is part of the ongoing story of the first five books of the Bible (Genesis 1:1–Deuteronomy 34:12). It is part of the history of God's saving actions. God chose Israel to be his people. He freed them from slavery in Egypt. Then, he made a covenant (special agreement) with them. Finally, God led them through the desert to the land promised to Abraham and his descendants.

Leviticus continues the story in Exodus 40:34–38. The Israelites had finished constructing the Tent of Meeting (the tabernacle). They consecrated the tabernacle (declared it holy) and the Lord filled it with his glory. Now, the Lord gives Moses instructions for how to worship at the tabernacle.

- the Tent of Meeting (see study note on Exod 27:21): This was God's palace represented on earth. Inside the Most Holy Place, the ark of the Covenant (or Testimony) represented God's throne (Exodus 40:1–33). The Lord's glory was between the cherubim's outstretched wings. This was where God would meet with the people of Israel. He would speak to them and tell them what he wanted them to do (see Exodus 25:22).

Leviticus 1:1–7:38

The first major section of Leviticus explains the sacrificial system and the priesthood. There were sacrifices for atonement (whole burnt offering, sin offering, and guilt offering). And there were sacrifices for worship (grain offering and peace offering). Each sacrifice taught Israel about God's character in practice.

Priests led the sacrificial worship at the Tent of Meeting (the tabernacle). They taught the people about God's revelations to Moses at Sinai. They represented the people before God, especially on the Day of Atonement (chapter 16). Priests received a portion of the offerings for their support.

Leviticus 1:2–3

- When: This introduces a major category, which is the process of presenting an offering. This is followed by conditions introduced by "if" (1:3, 10, 14). Leviticus 1:2–6:7 uses this when/if pattern throughout all the major offerings it describes.
- offering (Hebrew qorban; see study note on Mark 7:11) is a general term for all kinds of offerings and gifts, including those described in Leviticus 1–7.

Leviticus 1:3

an unblemished male: God allowed female and slightly deformed animals for some offerings not made for atonement (see 3:1; 4:27–31; 22:23). But the people could not use them for the whole burnt offering. In the dry, brush-covered hills of southern Palestine, raising cattle was harder than raising sheep or goats. This made a bull without defects very valuable. Centuries later, the prophet Malachi confronted the people for offering sick and lame animals instead of those without defects (Malachi 1:6–14).

Leviticus 1:3–17

burnt offering (Hebrew 'olah, which means "what goes up"): The Hebrew word suggests the animal rises up in flame and smoke. Its hide was not burned, but given to the officiating priest as payment (Leviticus 7:8). They completely burned this offering on the altar (1:9).

Its purpose was to turn away God's judgment against sin. It also makes the worshiper clean in a ceremonial way and restores his or her relationship with God (compare Romans 3:25; 8:3; 2 Corinthians 5:18–21). The whole burnt offering appears first in this list of offerings (Leviticus 1–7). It sets a pattern for the offerings that follow. It is the most common offering for atonement.

Leviticus 1:4

- He is to lay his hand on the head of the burnt offering: The sacrificial animal represented the worshiper in the ceremony (Leviticus 4:4, 15, 24, 29, 33; 16:21). This act showed that the animal's death represented the owner's death. During the Day of Atonement ceremony, it showed that God transferred the owner's sins to the animal (16:20–22). In the peace offering (3:2, 8, 13), the act probably showed ownership of the sacrificed animal.
- The phrase on his behalf may mean "as payment for sin" (sometimes called expiation) or "as a substitute for the sinner's death" (sometimes called propitiation).
- to make atonement for him: While older commentaries describe this as "covering over" sin, recent studies define it as "blotting out, erasing, or cleansing from" sin. The concept involves turning away God's judgment against sin, making the worshiper clean in a ceremonial way, and restoring fellowship with God and with the community of God's people.

Leviticus 1:5

- Aaron's sons: Moses was from the tribe of Levi. This tribe divided into two groups:

1. priests, who were descendants of Aaron, the first high priest; and
2. Levites, who served in supporting roles (Exodus 28:1–4; Numbers 18:1–7).

These instructions also applied to future generations.

- the blood: This symbolized life, not death. The basis of the Israelite sacrifice system was substitution. Shedding sacrificial blood was essential for atonement. It meant sacrificing the animal's life as a substitute for the worshiper's life (Leviticus 17:10–14; Hebrews 9:22). Jesus Christ's shed his blood as the ultimate sacrifice for sin (Hebrews 9:11–14).
- the altar of burnt offering was at the east end of the courtyard. It was outside the Tent of Meeting but inside the courtyard entrance (Exodus 40:6, 29).

Leviticus 1:6

The priest would burn the whole animal, except for the skin, which he kept as his share of the offering (Leviticus 7:8).

Leviticus 1:8

The Hebrew word for fat refers to the suet, or hard fat, around the kidneys and loins. This term appears only here and in Leviticus 1:12 and 8:20. All fat (not just this specific fat) belonged to God (3:14–17; 7:23–25; see 1 Samuel 2:15–17). The whole burnt offering was the only offering completely burned on the altar. For other offerings, they burned the fatty parts and some internal organs. The rest belonged to the officiating priests and sometimes the worshiper (Leviticus 7:11–18).

Leviticus 1:9

- They washed the offering with water to remove dirt or debris that might contaminate it. Washing was also necessary for purification from ceremonial uncleanness, a requirement for serving in the Tent of Meeting (Leviticus 6:27; 11:28).
- an offering made by fire: Traditional Bible versions translate the Hebrew term 'isheh this way. Although they did burn the offering (Leviticus 1:13, 17), recent research suggests the word meant "gift."
- a pleasing aroma to the LORD (literally a restful odor; also in Leviticus 1:13, 17): Pagans in the ancient Near East believed their gods smelled the offerings because they needed to eat them to live. God's response is sometimes described in ways that reflect this cultural setting (for example, Leviticus 21:6; Numbers 28:2). Yet, the Bible makes it clear that God did not need offerings as food (Psalm 50:9–13). Instead, they pleased him as sincere offerings for atonement.

Leviticus 1:10–13

The law allowed poorer Israelites to offer smaller animals so that atonement (a sacrifice that removes guilt and restores fellowship with God) would be more affordable. The way these animals were offered was very similar to the way bulls were offered (Leviticus 1:3–9).

Leviticus 1:14–17

Birds were plentiful, cheap, and easy to catch. This allowed both rich and poor people to participate in sacrifices for atonement and worship (see also Leviticus 5:7; 12:8; see Luke 2:24).

Leviticus 1:17

tear ... without dividing the bird completely: Cutting larger animals into pieces (like Leviticus 1:6, 12) probably reflects an ancient covenant-making ceremony. In this ceremony, participants passed between the two halves of a sacrificed animal (see Genesis 15:10). Because of their small size, people did not cut birds in half. If passing between them was necessary, they arranged the birds in pairs.

Leviticus 2:1

- fine flour was choice wheat flour, unlike common barley flour. See also 1 Kings 4:22; Ezekiel 16:13, 19.
- Israelites used olive oil for cooking, as lamp fuel, and for medicine and cosmetics. It represented the land's rich produce and God's provision (Deuteronomy 8:8).
- Like fine flour, Scripture often links frankincense with the tabernacle (Exodus 30:34; Leviticus 24:7) or the temple (1 Chronicles 9:29). Individuals also used this fragrant tree resin on special occasions (Song of Solomon 3:6; Matthew 2:11). It was a main ingredient in the holy incense burned in the Holy Place as a physical expression of worship (Exodus 30:34–38).

Leviticus 2:1–16

The grain offering (Hebrew minkhah, meaning "gift" or "present") allowed people to worship the Lord by giving a gift. It acknowledged the Lord's authority over the worshiper's life. People gave the grain offering with each whole burnt offering (Numbers 28:3–6, 12–13), sin offering (Numbers 6:14–15), and peace offering

(Leviticus 9:4; Numbers 6:17). The grain offering provided bread for the priest's daily needs, as priests did not have farmland.

Leviticus 2:2

The priest burned the main part of the grain offering on the altar. This reminded the worshiper that the whole offering belonged to God.

Leviticus 2:3

- The remainder of the grain offering: They usually reserved a part of the fire offerings for the priest as food (see 6:16–17). Exceptions included:

1. the whole burnt offering, where the priest only received the hide (see 7:8),
2. offerings given by the priest for himself (4:3–12; 6:19–23), or
3. offerings made for the entire community (4:13–21).

In these cases, they completely burned the offering. The grain offering provided the priests with bread for their diet.

- most holy part (Hebrew qodesh qodashim, which means "holy of holies"): Both God and what belongs to God are holy. The most holy part refers to the priestly share taken from the holy offering and reserved for a special purpose. Numbers 18:8–10 uses this term for the priest's share of any gifts dedicated to the Lord.

Leviticus 2:4

- They placed a large ceramic oven in a hole and lit a fire around it. Once the oven was hot, they baked flat cakes or wafers against its inner wall.
- unleavened: See study note on 2:11; see also Exodus 12:8.

Leviticus 2:5

A griddle was a flat stone or clay surface placed over a fire to heat it. Later, people made griddles from metal (Ezekiel 4:3).

Leviticus 2:7

The people fried dough in a pan with oil until it was crisp.

Leviticus 2:11

- leaven: The bread eaten in biblical times was like modern sourdough. What is often called leaven was wild yeast spores mixed into moist dough or flour. The leaven would grow, fermenting and becoming sour and raising the dough. They would save a portion of this sour dough to knead into future batches (Matthew 13:33).

Unleavened bread was necessary for Passover (Exodus 12:8). This was to remember Israel's slavery in Egypt (Deuteronomy 16:3) and their quick departure (Exodus 12:34; 13:3). After the exodus, unleavened bread became altar bread. They could not burn leavened bread on the altar.

- honey: The Hebrew word debash may also mean "fruit nectar." It is unknown why they did not burn it. But it might relate to its use in pagan offerings, especially to underworld gods. If it means "fruit nectar," its link with wine and fermentation might have connected it with leaven, making it unsuitable for the altar.

Yet, they could use both honey and yeast in first crop offerings (Leviticus 2:12). They would present loaves made with leaven with thank offerings (7:13). They gave them to the priest during the Festival of Harvest (23:17).

In the New Testament, leaven becomes a spiritual symbol, highlighting its sour taste and how it spreads (Matthew 16:6, 11, 12; 1 Corinthians 5:6–8; see also Matthew 13:33).

Leviticus 2:12

as an offering of firstfruits: Offering the first crops involved giving the first part of the harvest (Leviticus 23:15–21; Numbers 28:26–31). Like the main portion of the grain offering, this act acknowledged that the entire harvest belonged to God (Leviticus 23:10–11; Exodus 22:29; 23:19; 34:26; Numbers 15:18–20; Deuteronomy 18:4–5; 26:1–2). It also recognized that the land itself, not just its produce, belonged to God. Israel was only the tenant (see Leviticus 25:23).

Leviticus 2:13

In ancient times, people considered salt as a symbol of what is permanent because salt preserved food. The salt of the covenant represented a lasting agreement renewed with each new generation (see study notes on Numbers 18:19; 2 Chronicles 13:5).

Leviticus 3:1

- male or female: The whole burnt offering required male animals because it made atonement (Leviticus 1:3, 10). The less formal peace offering allowed both male and female animals (see also 4:28, 32).
- without blemish: The sacrificial animals had to be healthy. The only exception was the voluntary offering, which allowed a slight blemish (22:23).

Leviticus 3:1–17

The peace offering (called shelem in Hebrew) showed worship through fellowship with the Lord and others. The word comes from the same root as shalom, which means wholeness, well-being, harmony, and peace.

Shalom is more than just ending conflict between God and the worshiper. It means a bond of harmonious fellowship. The peace offering was a shared meal celebrating fellowship with God and others (compare Exodus 18:12; 24:9–11; 1 Samuel 9:15–24). They could offer it as thanks (Leviticus 7:12–15), as a voluntary offering, or to fulfill a vow (7:16–18; 22:21).

Peace offerings often came after whole burnt offerings (for example, 1 Kings 9:25). This showed that fellowship with God follows atonement. When we experience atonement through Christ, we can be at peace with God and each other (see Acts 2:42; 10:36; Romans 5:1; 1 Corinthians 10:16; 11:17–34; 2 Corinthians 5:18–21).

Leviticus 3:4

kidneys ... lobe of the liver: The kidneys and liver had special meaning for the Israelites.

They thought of kidneys as the place where understanding and deep thoughts came from, similar to how we think of the brain today. For example, "my heart yearns within me" [literally my kidneys are consumed] (Job 19:27). It can refer to "minds" (Psalms 7:9; Psalm 26:2; Jeremiah 17:10; Jeremiah 11:20; 20:12).

The liver represented life and energy to the Israelites, similar to how many cultures today understand the "heart" (Lamentations 2:11).

Leviticus 3:5

Leviticus 1:3–17 describes the burnt offering. It is more accurate to call it "the whole burnt offering." They offered it twice daily (see Numbers 28:4). God required atonement before fellowship with him. So, the text assumes the burnt offering was already on the altar. The priest would place the fatty portions and certain internal organs of the peace offering on top of it (Leviticus 3:3–4).

Leviticus 3:6–11

Sheep were smaller, easier to raise, and less expensive than cattle. Besides the exceptions mentioned in these verses, people offered sheep as sacrifices in the same way as cattle.

Leviticus 3:9

fat tail: In this region of the ancient Near East, sheep had wide, fatty tails. People burned these tails on the altar with the other fat.

Leviticus 3:11

- an offering made by fire: See study note on Leviticus 1:9.
- The Scripture calls offerings of food "the food of ... God" (Leviticus 21:6, 8, 17, 21, 22; Numbers 28:2). Yet, Scripture clearly states that the Lord did not eat the offerings, unlike pagan beliefs about their gods (Psalm 50:9–13). Instead, these offerings belonged to God, and the priest ate a portion as God's representative (Leviticus 21:21–22). These offerings provided for the priest and his family.

Leviticus 3:12–16

The offering of goats followed a similar pattern to that of cattle and sheep. People considered both goats and sheep as offerings from the flock (see Leviticus 3:6).

Leviticus 3:17

God did not allow the people to eat any fat or any blood (see Leviticus 1:5, 8, and study notes).

Leviticus 4:1–5.13

The sin offering is called khatta't in Hebrew, from the root khata'. It means "to lack, fall short, miss, fail." The people made this offering when they unintentionally violated specific commands of God (see also Numbers 15:22–29). The purpose of this offering was to repair a loss or fix a failure (for example, Leviticus 5:1–4).

Although all Christians sin, God will forgive us if we confess them (Galatians 6:1; 1 John 1:8–9). Yet, the Scripture warns against sinning "defiantly" or "deliberately" (Numbers 15:30–31; Hebrews 10:26–29; 6:4–6).

Leviticus 4:3

- God chose the high priest for a special role and they anointed him. The Hebrew word for "anoint" is mashiakh. It means "set apart by the ritual of anointing." In 1 Samuel 1:1—2 Kings 25:30, anointing usually refers to Israel's king (see 1 Samuel 24:6; 2 Samuel 1:14; 19:21).

They would anoint all priests (Exodus 40:13–15). Yet, here the term probably refers to the high priest because they specially anointed him for service in the tabernacle (Leviticus 6:20; 8:12). The high priest acted as a mediator or intercessor for all of Israel, including

other priests. His sin would bring guilt on the entire community (see "Community Identity" Theme Note).

- Guilt in this sense comes from disobeying God's will. It is not only a feeling in the mind but a real offense against God (see study note on Leviticus 5:17–19).

Leviticus 4:3–21

These verses describe two types of sin offerings:

1. The offering for the sin of the high priest (Leviticus 4:3, 20) and the entire Israelite community (4:13).
2. The offering for one of Israel's leaders (4:22) and any common person (4:27).

The first type required a bull, a large and expensive animal. It was not eaten (6:30) but completely burned (4:12, 21). The priests presented some of its blood in the Holy Place (4:6–7, 17–18).

The second type required a smaller animal. This was a male goat for a leader or a female sheep or goat for a common person. The priest ate part of the common person's offering (6:24–29). The priest would present the blood at the bronze altar in the courtyard (4:25, 30).

This distinction highlights the responsibilities of leaders. The offering was the same for the priest and the entire community. But the leader's offering was more than that of a common person.

The New Testament also emphasizes the responsibility of religious leaders. God will judge those who teach and those who serve as religious leaders more strictly than their followers (James 3:1; Matthew 23:1–33; Luke 20:47).

Leviticus 4:5–6

The tabernacle area had a tent (sometimes called the "Tent of Meeting"; (see study note on 1:1). The tent was at the west end of the courtyard. Inside the tent, an inner curtain separated the first room, the Holy Place, from the second, the Most Holy Place. The Most Holy Place contained the ark of the Covenant (or Testimony) and represented God's throne room (Exodus 26:31–33; see study note on Leviticus 1:1).

The priests would sprinkle the animal's blood in front of the curtain (Leviticus 4:6, 17). They would also apply it to the horns of the incense altar (4:7, 18). This would atone for the anointed priest or the entire congregation. This action showed the seriousness of the offenses that needed atonement (compare 4:25, 30–35).

Leviticus 4:7

the altar for fragrant incense: This was in front of the inner curtain, just outside the Most Holy Place (Leviticus 4:6). It had four projections that looked like horns, similar to the altar for burnt offerings (see study note on Exodus 27:2). The priests burned incense on this altar to the Lord each morning and evening (Exodus 30:1–10).

Leviticus 4:11–12

They would only burn the offerings for the priest or the entire community outside the camp. God might have commanded this because the offering had symbolically taken on the impurity (uncleanness) of the high priest or the community. So, they had to remove it outside the camp. The guilty people could not participate in or gain any benefit from their own sin offerings. This was true even for priests (Leviticus 6:19–23).

Leviticus 4:15

The Hebrew word for elders is related to the word for "beard." It suggests maturity but not necessarily old age. Elders were community leaders, usually leaders of families and tribes (see Exodus 18:21–26; Deuteronomy 22:15–19). For this offering, the elders represented all the people, as they did later when anointing David as king (2 Samuel 5:3).

Leviticus 4:20

The phrase they will be forgiven often appears in passages about atonement (Leviticus 4:26, 31, 35; 5:10, 13, 16, 18; 6:7; 19:22; Numbers 15:25, 26, 28). God is willing to forgive a repentant person's sin and allow him or her to return to the community of faith.

Leviticus 4:22

Israel's leaders included the elders (see Leviticus 4:15), chiefs of tribes and families (see Numbers 1:16, 44; 1 Kings 8:1).

Leviticus 4:22–35

The sin offerings in this passage atoned for the common people, including leaders and other Israelites. These offerings could be eaten, unlike those in Leviticus 4:3–21, and involved smaller animals. They disposed of the blood in the tabernacle courtyard, not the Holy Place.

Like the peace offering in chapter 3, they burned the fat and certain internal organs on the altar. The priest and his male family members ate the rest of the meat

in a holy place (6:29; 6:26; compare 10:16–20). A lay leader offered a male goat (4:23), while a common person could offer a female goat or lamb.

The smaller size and cost of the animal reflected that the common person had less influence. It probably related to their financial situation as well. Those who were poor could bring a pair of doves or young pigeons (5:7–8; 12:6, 8; compare Luke 2:24). The very poor could offer two quarts of flour (Leviticus 5:11).

Leviticus 4:23

The male goat offered by a leader from the common people was less than the priest's required offering. A priest must offer a bull. But the leader must offer more than a common person's requirement (see Leviticus 4:28, 32). Yet, like all offerings for atonement, the animal could not have any defects (see 1:3).

Leviticus 4:24

at the place where the burnt offering is slaughtered: See Leviticus 1:3–5.

Leviticus 4:25

blood ... horns of the altar: They did not take the blood of a leader's offering (Leviticus 4:25) or a common Israelite's offering (4:30, 34) into the Holy Place. The blood of the priest's bull offering entered the Holy Place. The priest who offered would eat a portion of the meat (6:24–29).

Leviticus 4:27–35

The common people, with fewer responsibilities than priests or leaders, could offer a female sheep or goat. More important social positions required more responsibility (see Amos 3:2; Matthew 25:14–30; James 3:1).

Leviticus 5:1

- The first sin was not testifying when summoned as a witness in court. This verse considers not testifying to be an active sin. This was because it helped the criminal.
- he shall bear the iniquity: Expecting God's punishment for the sin, the guilty person offered a sacrifice to remove the guilt and escape the punishment.

Leviticus 5:1–6

These verses give examples of sins that required a sin offering (Leviticus 4:2). When a person became aware of committing a wrong, the next step to make it right was to admit the guilt and bring a sin offering.

Leviticus 5:2

unclean: "Clean" and "unclean" did not relate to hygiene (see Leviticus 11:1–15:33). They referred to whether someone could participate in worship. For animals, it meant if they were suitable for sacrifice or eating. There is a list of ceremonially clean and unclean animals in 11:1–47.

To become ceremonially clean after touching an unclean animal, a person had to wash their clothes. They also had to stay away from the community until evening (11:25). This sin offering probably shows that the person did not follow the rules for cleansing (11:27–28).

Leviticus 5:3

Any bodily discharge, including blood, made a person temporarily unclean (chapters Leviticus 11–15). Being ceremonially unclean was not the same as sin. But if someone ignored their unclean state and did not take the required steps, that became sin because it allowed the impurity to spread. Once a person realized they were unclean, they were guilty if they ignored it.

Leviticus 5:4

People were allowed to take oaths in the name of the Lord. But making a foolish or careless vow misused the Lord's name and showed disrespect (Exodus 20:7). For this reason, the law required people to keep the vows they made (see Numbers 30:2; Deuteronomy 23:21–23; Ecclesiastes 5:4–6).

Leviticus 5:5

- If someone incurs guilt: Situations needing a sin offering assumed there was guilt that happened by accident or ignorance. Once someone realized they did something wrong, they became guilty and needed to receive atonement. If someone knew they sinned, they must deal with it. To know what was right and not do it was also a sin (see 5:17; James 4:17).
- confess: Offering a sacrifice for sin without admitting guilt was a pointless ceremony. When presenting the sacrificial animal to the priest, the worshiper probably explained the reason for the offering.

Leviticus 5:6

- The required sacrifice fulfilled the penalty (see study note on Leviticus 4:1–5:13).
- The actions described in Leviticus 5:1–5 seem to apply to orindary people, not priests. For this reason, the law allowed the use of a female animal for the

offering, following the same principle shown in 4:28, 32.

Leviticus 5:7

a sin offering: This included part as a burnt offering and part given to the priests after they made the offering (compare Leviticus 4:22–35; 6:24–30). Due to their small size, it required two birds (one for each type of offering).

Leviticus 5:7–13

Poor people also needed to receive atonement and be restored to God. For those who could not afford a lamb, the law allowed them to bring birds instead (Leviticus 5:7; compare 1:14–17). Normally, atonement required the blood of an animal (17:11). But in his grace, God permitted even an offering of flour when a person was too poor to afford two birds (5:11).

Leviticus 5:11

The sin offering was not to include olive oil or frankincense on it. These were necessary for the grain offering, which was a person's gift to the Lord to show worship (see Leviticus 2:1). The sin offering, however, was different. It was meant to make atonement and bring forgiveness, so it had to be offered without anything added.

Leviticus 5:13

- will make atonement for him: See study notes on Leviticus 1:4 and 4:20.
- The remainder: See study note on 2:3.

Leviticus 5:14–6.7

The guilt offering (called 'asham in Hebrew, meaning "guilt") dealt with cases of property loss or damage. This could be either holy property set apart for God (Leviticus 5:14–16) or ordinary property belong to a person (6:1–7). The offering required both replacement and repayment for the loss (5:16; 6:5).

This offering could be called a "penalty offering" because the ram served as a penalty. It could also be called a "replacement offering" because a person had to replace the loss before offering the ram. In the guilt offering, the loss was not only a failure in God's eyes, as with the sin offering (5:14–6:7). It was also a loss of property to another person or to the sanctuary. Compare Matthew 5:23–24.

Leviticus 5:15

- sins unintentionally: Damage to sacred property (objects or land set apart for God) was treated differently from damage to ordinary property. A sacrifice could only restore sacred property if the damage was done by accident. If someone harmed sacred things on purpose, such as vandalizing them, it was considered blasphemy (disrespect toward God).

As with other deliberate sins, there was no specific way to atone for it (see Numbers 15:30–31). A true believer would not defiantly continue in sin (see 1 John 3:9).

- sanctuary shekel: This was not a coin but a standardized unit of weight. They used it to evaluate the offered ram. Some scholars suggest this text allows substituting the appropriate amount of silver for the ram.

Leviticus 5:16

The law required an extra payment of 20 percent to make up for loss or damage to property. If the property was sacred (set apart for God), the extra payment went directly to the priests. Accidental damage to sacred property happened when someone unintentionally ate the sacred offerings or forgot the tithe (Leviticus 22:14; 27:31). A similar additional charge applied when redeeming an animal (27:13, 27).

Leviticus 5:17–19

This paragraph explains the main principles of the guilt offering. Even if someone did not know they did something wrong, they were still guilty and had to give the right guilt offering. This rule applied to both sacred property (set apart for God) and ordinary property (Leviticus 5:14–16; 6:1–7).

Leviticus 6:2

If someone sins and acts unfaithfully against the LORD by deceiving his neighbor: FWhen a person sins against an associate, they are also unfaithful to the Lord. For believers, there is no such thing as a nonreligious (secular) sin. Every sin involves God, even when it is directed against another person or group.

In these cases, a guilt offering was required. God's forgiveness was needed, but the sinner first had to make restitution (pay back or repair the wrong) to the injured person (Leviticus 6:5–7; compare Matthew 5:23–24). Unlike offenses against sacred property (Leviticus 5:14–16), both accidental and intentional offenses against another person's property could be forgiven.

Leviticus 6:5

The instructions for the guilt offering assumed a person's conscience would lead them to voluntary repayment. When replacement was voluntary, the extra charge for loss of use to the owner was always 20 percent. Penalties were more severe in other cases (compare Exodus 22:1–15). There is a clear difference between voluntary confession and admitting sin only after being caught.

Leviticus 6:7

In this way the priest will make atonement for him before the LORD: God kindly provided his people a way to atone for their sins (atonement refers to the process by which God and humanity are reconnected and brought into a personal relationship). See also study notes on 1:4; 4:20.

Leviticus 6:8–7.38

The regulations in Leviticus 1:2–6:7 include instructions for both priests and ordinary Israelites. This section details the rights and duties of the priest who led the offerings. The tribe of Levi received no land for farming (Deuteronomy 18:1; Joshua 13:14, 33). Priests relied on offerings for their income. These rules made sure the priests were properly provided for. Like many human systems, the offering system was later abused (1 Samuel 2:12–25; Hosea 4:8).

Leviticus 6:10

- The priest had to wear official linen clothing while serving at the tabernacle. This showed everyone he was performing his duties (Exodus 28:40–43). The priest needed to dress properly to serve the divine king. He could not wear his official clothing outside the tabernacle (Leviticus 6:11; Ezekiel 44:19).
- undergarments: See Exodus 20:26.

Leviticus 6:11

The Israelites viewed most natural places as ceremonially clean.

Leviticus 6:12–13

This passage warns that the fire on the bronze altar must always remain tended and never allowed to go out. This may anticipate the tragedy of the "unauthorized fire" offered by Nadab and Abihu (Leviticus 10:1–2).

Leviticus 6:16

Here, holy place does not refer to the Holy Place at the center of the tabernacle. It refers to any area within the tabernacle area, all of which were ceremonially clean and holy.

Leviticus 6:17

- leaven: See study note on 2:11.
- The priests received a portion of the grain offering. This provided bread, which was their main food (7:9). It also had spiritual meaning, because it was considered most holy. See study note on 2:3.

Leviticus 6:18

- The priestly share was not only for the priest performing the sacrifice. All of Aaron's male descendants shared it. The text does not explain why only males could eat these offerings, although other offerings were for all priestly family members (see study note on Leviticus 10:13–15; see also Numbers 18:20–24).
- will become holy (Or must be holy; also in Leviticus 6:27): Although uncleanness could spread by touch (chapter 15), the prophet Haggai suggested that holiness could not (Haggai 2:12). If a ceremonially unclean person touched something holy, it could lead to disaster (Leviticus 10:1–3; 1 Samuel 6:19–20; 2 Samuel 6:6–8).

Leviticus 6:19–23

These instructions only apply to the grain part of the ordination offering (see Leviticus 2:1–16). For the rest of the ordination offering, see 8:22–32.

Leviticus 6:22

Only the high priest could represent the whole priesthood, including all the other priests.

Leviticus 6:23

Normally, most of a grain offering went to the priest who led the ceremony (Leviticus 2:9–10). But the grain offering in 6:19–23 was for a special event, the ordination of the priests. Ordination means setting apart the priests for their service to the Lord. This offering had to be burned completely and not eaten.

Leviticus 6:28

A clay pot was porous and could not be cleaned well. Some of the holy food might stick to it or soak into it. Using the pot again would dishonor what was holy.

But a bronze pot could be scrubbed clean to prevent this problem (see also Leviticus 11:33; 15:12).

Leviticus 6:30

The anointed priest and the entire congregation could not eat some sin offerings. The priest took the blood from these offerings into the Holy Place and sprinkled it in front of the curtain (see Leviticus 4:1–21). The lay leader and the ordinary Israelites could eat the sacrifices. The priest poured the blood of these animals on and around the base of the altar in the tabernacle courtyard (see 4:22–35).

Leviticus 7:3–4

- The guilt offering required sacrificing a ram (Leviticus 5:18).
- the fat ... fat tail ... organs: They burned these parts of the guilt offering, just like in the peace offering (3:3–4, 9–10, 14–15) and the sin offering (4:8–9, 26, 31, 35).

Leviticus 7:12–15

Worshipers would present the peace offering for three reasons:

1. as thanks to God,
2. as payment of a vow (Leviticus 7:16), or
3. as a voluntary gift (see 3:1–7).

A worshiper showed thanks by giving a grain offering with the peace offering (2:1–16). A grain offering included unleavened cakes, wafers, or fine flour cakes. They mixed all of them or spread olive oil on them. They set aside a portion to burn (2:9). The grain offering came with loaves of "leavened bread" (7:13).

Leviticus 7:15

Worshipers presented the thanksgiving offering as an expression of gratitude (Jeremiah 17:26; 33:11). They had to eat the sacrifice on the same day they offered it. This rule helped the worshiper remember the reason for giving thanks.

Leviticus 7:16–18

Worshipers presented the "peace offering of thanksgiving" to show gratitude to the Lord (Leviticus 7:12–15). This was unlike the vow offering linked to a promise made by a worshiper. After, they celebrated with a meal. The meal was less formal and could continue into the next day. But since the vow offering involved a promise to God, it had stricter rules than the voluntary offering, which could even use a deformed animal (22:23).

Leviticus 7:18

The Hebrew word piggul means "contaminated." It appears only three other times in the Bible (Leviticus 19:7; Isaiah 65:4; Ezekiel 4:14). This term always refers to meat that is not suitable for humans to sacrifice or eat.

Leviticus 7:19–21

Anything ceremonially unclean could not touch what was holy (Leviticus 7:20). Although uncleanness was not sinful by itself, it symbolized what was unholy (see Exodus 19:10).

Leviticus 7:20–21

cut off: This expression can mean three serious things:

1. God judged the person, and they died early from natural causes (Leviticus 17:10–14).
2. The community executed the person (see Exodus 31:14).
3. The person lost membership in Israel. This was either by expulsion (like excommunication) or being shunned and treated as ceremonially unclean (Leviticus 18:24–30; see 23:29–30, where "cut off" seems different from "destroy").

Leviticus 7:22–27

In the sacrificial system, the fat and blood of all altar offerings belonged to God. People offered them before eating any part of the sacrifice. God forbid the Israelites of consuming blood because it represented the animal's life (Leviticus 17:10–16). The rule against eating fat might have been because fat, considered the best part, belonged to God.

Leviticus 7:24

Animals found dead had not been drained of their blood and were therefore unclean. Their fat was unfit to offer to the Lord and the Israelites could not eat it. But people could use it for other purposes, such as greasing cart axles, waterproofing animal hides, and other household uses.

Leviticus 7:26–27

The command not to eat blood was very important. The Council at Jerusalem even included it in their instructions for non-Jewish (Gentile) believers (Acts 15:29).

Leviticus 7:34

the breast of the wave offering and the thigh of the contribution of their peace offerings: God, the priest, the worshiper, and guests shared this meal. Some

translations call the breast a "wave offering" and the thigh the "contribution" or "heave offering." These were specifically for the priest (see Leviticus 10:13–15). After presenting these offerings in the tabernacle in front of the Lord, they ate them (see Exodus 29:24, 26).

Leviticus 7:36

anointed: See Leviticus 8:12, 30; also Exodus 40:13–15.

Leviticus 8:1–36

In Exodus 28–29, the Lord gave Moses detailed instructions for clothing and ordaining Aaron and his sons as priests. In Exodus 39:1–31; 40:12–16; and Leviticus 8, they followed these commands. Moses did not only tell them the instructions. He performed the ceremonies to show the priests exactly what to do, as the Lord had commanded him (8:9, 13, 17, 21, 29). Since disobedience could lead to death, God ensured the priests understood their duties clearly.

Leviticus 8:2

- Exodus 29:1–3, 7 also mentions these items.
- garments: See Exodus 28.
- The anointing oil had special ingredients that gave it a special smell. These included myrrh, cinnamon, cane, and cassia (dried flowers from the cinnamon tree) mixed into olive oil (see Exodus 30:22–33).
- bull of the sin offering: See Leviticus 4:3–12.
- The first of the two rams was a whole burnt offering (8:18), while the second was a special ordination sacrifice (8:22).
- basket of unleavened bread: See 6:19–23.

Leviticus 8:4

The text repeatedly emphasizes that Moses did what the Lord instructed. He obeyed the commands God gave in Exodus 29 (see also Leviticus 8:9, 13, 17, 21, 29, 36).

Leviticus 8:6

washed them with water: This was the first step to remove impurity. The priests needed to be ceremonially clean before serving the Lord in holiness (Exodus 29:4; see Psalm 24:4).

Leviticus 8:7

- The priestly tunic was woven from patterned linen cloth (see Exodus 28:39).
- The Israelites used same material for the tabernacle curtains as with the embroidered ephod (see Exodus 28:4, 6–14). The exact shape and size of the ephod are not known, but it seems to have been a long, sleeveless vest. It fit closely to the body and tied at the waist. Gold settings joined it at the shoulders, each holding an onyx stone engraved with the names of six tribes of Israel (Exodus 28:9). Later, an ephod also referred to a honored image (Judges 8:27; 18:17).
- They embroidered and made the decorative sash from the same materials as the ephod (see Exodus 28:8).

Leviticus 8:8

- The breastpiece (see Exodus 28:15–30) was made it from embroidered linen folded in half. It had twelve stones, each engraved with the name of an Israelite tribe. A gold chain from the gold shoulder pieces of the ephod held it over the chest.
- The priests placed the Urim and Thummim in the breastpiece pocket (Exodus 28:30; 1 Samuel 23:9–12; 30:7–8). Their exact purpose is unclear. Most scholars think they are two stones, possibly different in color, that were cast as lots. They could give a positive, neutral, or negative answer to difficult questions (Exodus 28:30; Numbers 27:21; 1 Samuel 28:6). Their mention in later Old Testament prophetic writings shows how important these items were for the work of the priest (Ezra 2:63; Nehemiah 7:65).

Leviticus 8:9

The turban worn by the high priest was made of linen. It was different from the headdresses the common priests wore (Exodus 28:40). A gold medallion hung from the turban. It had the words "HOLY TO THE LORD" inscribed on it (Exodus 28:36). With the names of the tribes on his shoulders and over his heart and the dedication to the Lord on his forehead, the high priest was clearly marked as the people's representative to God and God's representative to the people. In this role, the high priest mediated for the people and modeled the standard for all priests.

Leviticus 8:10

he consecrated them (or he made them holy): God is "the Holy One" (Psalm 78:41; 22:3). Only God can truly make a person or thing holy (Leviticus 20:8; 21:15, 23; 22:9, 16, 32; Exodus 31:13; see Hebrews 2:11). Moses poured the anointing oil on the tabernacle and everything in it. This action showed that God had chosen these objects and set them apart for worship (also in Leviticus 8:11, 12, 15).

Leviticus 8:13

To learn about the clothing of common priests, see Exodus 28:40–41.

Leviticus 8:14

- sin offering (see 4:3–12): They made two offerings for atonement:

1. the sin offering (8:14–17) and
2. the whole burnt offering (8:18–21).

- By placing their hands on the bull's head (see 1:4), Aaron and his sons identified themselves with the sacrifice (also in 8:18, 22).

Leviticus 8:15

Normally, the high priest performed these duties. Yet, priests could not ordain themselves. So, Moses, as God's representative, established the priesthood.

Leviticus 8:18

ram for the burnt offering: See the study note on Leviticus 1:10–13.

Leviticus 8:22

ram of ordination: See Exodus 29:19–34.

Leviticus 8:23

Aaron's right earlobe ... thumb ... big toe: These body parts represented the total person. This act emphasized the priest's role, with the blood stressing connections to the sacrificial system. The priest's main job was to mediate between God and his people. To do this well, he needed ears to hear God's words and his people's needs. He also needed hands ready to obey God's commands, and feet ready to go where needed.

Leviticus 8:29

Moses acted as a priest during the ordination ceremony, so he received the priest's portion of the offering (see Leviticus 8:15).

Leviticus 8:30

anointing oil: See the study note on Leviticus 8:2; see also Psalm 133:2.

Leviticus 8:31

The ordination offering was a type of peace offering (Exodus 29:28). It was a meal shared between God and the priests (Leviticus 7:11–18, 28–34). The parts of the offering burned on the altar belonged to God. The command to boil and eat the ordination offerings first appears in Exodus 29:32.

Leviticus 8:34

commanded by the LORD: The details of the sacrifice ceremonies were symbolic and important. But the most important part was for the priests to obey God's commands. Complete obedience to God is a major theme in both the Old Testament and the New Testament: "obedience is better than sacrifice" (1 Samuel 15:22).

Leviticus 8:35

seven days: This command emphasized God's complete holiness and required strict obedience to his commands. The priests, now anointed as God's holy servants, had to stay in the tabernacle court for seven days before returning to daily life.

Leviticus 9:1

- eighth day: The priests completed the seven-day probation period as commanded in Leviticus 8:35.
- elders: See the study note on Leviticus 4:15.

Leviticus 9:2–4

At the start of the priests' ministry, several sacrifices were required. The priests offered a sin offering and a whole burnt offering. The people offered a sin offering, a burnt offering, a peace offering, and a grain offering. These sacrifices made sure that all sin was atoned for and the covenant with God was affirmed. The only sacrifice not included was the guilt offering.

Leviticus 9:6

Just as holiness describes God's character, the glory of the LORD shows God's power and majesty (see Ezekiel 1:28; 10:4). God's glory appeared:

- on Mount Sinai (Exodus 24:16),
- at the dedication of the tabernacle (Exodus 40:34–35), and
- in Solomon's temple (1 Kings 8:11; 2 Chronicles 7:1).

But God's glory also fills the heavens (Psalm 19:1).

The New Testament describes Christ's glory as the image of God (2 Corinthians 4:4), who showed God's glory to the world (John 1:14). God glorified Christ in his death and resurrection (John 17:1–5). See also Exodus 24:15–17.

Leviticus 9:7

your sin offering and your burnt offering: Before the high priest could make atonement for the people, he first had to be right with God himself.

Leviticus 9:9

- Both Aaron, the high priest , and his sons, the common priests, took part in the sin offering and the burnt offering (Leviticus 9:8–14). Their shared work made atonement effective for the whole priesthood.
- horns of the altar: See study note on Leviticus 4:25; see also Exodus 27:1–8.

Leviticus 9:17

the morning's burnt offering: They offered a lamb as a whole burnt offering each morning and evening (Leviticus 6:9; Numbers 28:2–4).

Leviticus 9:22

blessed them: See Numbers 6:22–27.

Leviticus 9:24

Fire came out from the presence of the LORD: This showed that God accepted the offerings, the atonement, and the priesthood (Leviticus 9:7; compare 1 Kings 18:36–38).

Leviticus 10:1

- Aaron's sons Nadab and Abihu (Exodus 6:23): These were Aaron's oldest sons who had gone with Moses and the seventy elders to Mount Sinai (Exodus 24:1, 9). They also saw the great theophany (appearance of God) there. They died without male children (see also Exodus 28:1; Numbers 3:2–4; 26:60–61; 1 Chronicles 6:3; 24:1–2).
- censers: These were fire pans or trays for holding hot coals. They sprinkled incense on them (Exodus 30:34–38; see also Leviticus 16:12–13; 2 Chronicles 26:19; Revelation 8:3–4).
- unauthorized fire: The Hebrew phrase 'esh zarah means "strange fire." This could mean "foreign," and thus "unauthorized" (see Exodus 30:9) or even "pagan" (as in Psalm 44:20; 81:9).

It seems that Nadab and Abihu used fire from a source not approved by God (Numbers 3:4; 26:61). It could have been even a pagan source. They might have offered incense not prepared according to God's instructions (Exodus 30:34–38). The text does not mention that though. They entered God's presence in their own way, not his.

Leviticus 10:1–20

A fire was to burn all the time on the bronze altar. Its coals were to be used for burning incense (Leviticus 6:9; 16:12). Nadab and Abihu, perhaps careless because they had been drinking wine (10:8–11), took coals from another place. This broke God's command, and they died as a result.

Leviticus 10:2

In Leviticus 9:24, the fire showed God's acceptance. Now, it shows his disapproval by causing the death of Nadab and Abihu. They had shown a careless attitude toward worshiping God (compare Acts 5:1–11).

Leviticus 10:3

God's holiness is central to his character, different from the world of creatures. By acting recklessly, Nadab and Abihu ignored God's holiness and did not honor him.

Leviticus 10:4

- Mishael and Elzaphan...uncle Uzziel: See Exodus 6:18, 22.
- carry the bodies of your cousins: Aaron, the high priest, and the priests Eleazar and Ithamar could not touch a dead person because it would make them ceremonially unclean (Leviticus 10:6; 21:10–12).

Leviticus 10:5

They carried the bodies by their clothes to avoid contamination.

Leviticus 10:6

- Eleazar and Ithamar were Aaron's two remaining sons (Exodus 6:23).
- let your hair become disheveled: In biblical times, this and similar practices showed grief (see Genesis 37:29; 44:13; Deuteronomy 14:1; 2 Samuel 1:11; Job 1:20; Jeremiah 16:6; 47:5). As high priest, Aaron could not participate in these ceremonies or show his grief (Leviticus 21:10). This rule also applied to Eleazar and Ithamar. If God's representatives had shown grief, people might have thought they disagreed with God's justice. But the common people were allowed to mourn.

Leviticus 10:7

- Eleazar and Ithamar could not attend the funeral.
- the LORD's anointing oil: They had recently become priests (see Leviticus 7:36), so they had to avoid any contact with the dead.

Leviticus 10:8–10

- The placement of this instruction suggests that Nadab and Abihu might have been drinking alcohol when they offered the "unauthorized fire" (Leviticus 10:1). Priests should not drink anything that could

impair their judgment before serving in the tabernacle.
- the Lord said to Aaron: Previously, God communicated only with Moses, but now he accepted Aaron as the people's representative and spoke directly to him.
- The word common means "secular" or "ordinary."
- clean and the unclean: See Leviticus 7:19–21; 11:1–15:33.

Leviticus 10:11

God's decrees were laws given directly by God, not decided by a human court.

Leviticus 10:12

- the grain offering: This was part of the ordination ceremony (see Leviticus 8:26; Exodus 29:2, 23).
- without leaven beside the altar, because it is most holy: Moses wanted to be certain no fermentation had occurred in the priest's portion of the grain offering (Leviticus 6:14–18).

Leviticus 10:13–15

The priest's share of the grain, sin, and guilt offerings was "most holy" (see Leviticus 2:3; 6:29; 7:6). Only the males in the priest's family could eat it. They had to eat it in a holy place, like the tabernacle court. Yet, the priest's portion of the peace offering was only "holy." Any family member could eat it in any clean place (22:10–13).

Leviticus 10:16–17

The goat of the sin offering was the offering for the people (Leviticus 9:3, 15–17; compare 9:2, 8–11). On this special occasion, the priests did not take the blood into the Holy Place as usually required. After offering the parts meant for God, the priests should have eaten the remaining portion (see 6:29). But they burned the entire goat, even though its blood had not entered the sanctuary (10:18; see 6:30).

Leviticus 10:19

Since these things have happened to me: Aaron may have meant two things. He could have been saying that eating the goat of the sin offering would not have stopped the deaths of Nadab and Abihu. Or he may have meant that it was not right for him to eat it immediately after such a painful event.

Leviticus 11:1–15.33

These chapters explain the rules about purity. Mixing different types of animals was forbidden (see Deuteronomy 22:9–11). This is because it opposed God's natural order. Creatures like fish without fins and scales, meat-eating animals, crawling insects, and animals without split hooves were considered "abnormal." They crossed the boundaries between "normal" types and were not suitable for food or offerings (see also Deuteronomy 14:1–21). The dietary laws intended to set Israel apart as a holy people from other nations (Leviticus 11:44–45).

Leviticus 11:2–3

these ones you may eat: The Israelites considered animals with split hooves that chew cud to be "normal" and ceremonially clean (see also Deuteronomy 14:3–21).

Leviticus 11:2–8

Some scholars think people avoided ceremonially unclean animals for health reasons. But evidence does not support this suggestion. Horse meat, for instance, is as healthy as beef, yet it was "unclean" because the horse does not have a split hoof (see Leviticus 11:2–3). These rules existed because an unclean animal was not suitable as an offering to God. So, it was likewise not suitable as food for God's people.

Jesus proclaimed all foods clean for Christians (Mark 7:14–19). This teaching was confirmed in Peter's vision (Acts 10:9–16).

Leviticus 11:5–6

The rock badger and the rabbit do not actually chew cud, even though it looks like they do. They are ceremonially unclean because they lack split hooves.

Leviticus 11:9

the creatures that live in the water: The Israelites considered animals from the water to be clean (acceptable for food and for ritual use) only if they had both fins and scales

Leviticus 11:10

The prohibition included fish like eels and sharks, which have fins but no scales. It also included crustaceans and mollusks, which have neither fins nor scales.

Leviticus 11:13–19

The list of ceremonially unclean birds includes birds of prey and scavengers. These birds often touch dead animals and blood, making them unclean and unfit for eating and offerings. Bats fly but are not birds (Leviti-

cus 11:19). So, they are "abnormal" and ceremonially unclean.

Leviticus 11:21–22

insects that walk on all fours: those having jointed legs above their feet: This phrase excludes creatures that creep or crawl close to the ground (Leviticus 11:27). Leviticus 11:42 says that creatures with many legs, like centipedes, are ceremonially unclean. Locusts and grasshoppers are examples of ceremonially clean insects (see Matthew 3:4).

Leviticus 11:24–25

unclean until evening: Anyone who touched a ceremonially unclean animal that was dead would be unclean until evening. In Israel, evening marked the start of the next day.

Leviticus 11:29–31

This list of ceremonially unclean creatures that crawl includes both warm-blooded and cold-blooded animals that move along the ground. Snakes are also part of this group (Leviticus 11:42).

Leviticus 11:32–40

Dead animals could make objects and people ceremonially unclean. Even a ceremonially clean animal that died without its blood drained was unclean (Leviticus 11:39–40). If a person touched the body of a dead animal, they were unclean until evening. Household items that touched the body of a dead animal needed purification or the people had to destroy the items (11:25, 28, 32, 40; 11:33, 35).

Leviticus 11:36

A cistern was a hole dug into the ground or rock. They often lined it with plaster to hold rain and surface water.

Leviticus 11:37–38

People probably moistened grain with water to cook it for food. Eating contaminated grain was like eating a dead animal. But if they planted the grain, the new plant and its grain were ceremonially clean.

Leviticus 11:39–40

Israelites could not consume blood (Leviticus 7:26). They could eat an animal only after draining and properly disposing of the blood (17:13). If a ceremonially clean animal died naturally and did not have its blood drained, it became ceremonially unclean. An Israelite could give or sell such an animal to foreigners but could not eat it (Deuteronomy 14:21).

Leviticus 11:44–45

- I am the LORD your God: See study note on Leviticus 18:2.
- be holy, because I am holy: These words express the main theme of Leviticus: God is holy. They must consider and treat God as holy. God expects holiness from his people (Leviticus 10:3; 19:2). This verse teaches that God's character influences those who make a covenant with him (see also 11:45; 20:7, 26; 21:8, 15; 22:9, 16, 32). They must become holy in their actions (Exodus 22:31; Deuteronomy 28:9; compare 1 Peter 1:16).

Leviticus 11:45

brought you up out of the land of Egypt: This phrase or a similar one appears often in the first five books of the Bible (see Leviticus 19:36; 22:33; 25:38; 26:13; Exodus 13:9; 20:2; Numbers 15:41; Deuteronomy 4:37). Each time, it reminds the Israelites, God's chosen people, of God's great act of freeing them from Egypt. Other verses in the Old Testament often mention the exodus event (Psalms 80:8; 106:21; Isaiah 11:16; Jeremiah 34:13; Hosea 12:9; 13:4; Amos 2:10).

Leviticus 12:1–8

These verses explain the rules about childbirth. Any bodily discharge, including blood, was "abnormal" because it weakened the person and made them ceremonially unclean (see study notes on Leviticus 5:3; 11:1–15:33). These verses focus on the discharge that comes with childbirth, not childbirth itself (12:2, 5, 7). The uncleanness was not sinful unless they ignored it and it came into contact with something holy (see 5:2–3).

Leviticus 12:2

her menstruation: See Leviticus 15:19–24.

Leviticus 12:3

By the eighth day, a baby's body has developed enough for blood to clot well. This made circumcision safer at that time.

Leviticus 12:4

These thirty-three days, plus the previous seven days mentioned in Leviticus 12:2, 3 make a total of forty days for the mother's period of purification.

Leviticus 12:5

two weeks ... sixty-six days: The total is eighty days. This is double the purification time needed for a son's birth (see also Leviticus 27:2–7).

Leviticus 12:6

sin offering: The Hebrew word is the same as the sin offering (khatta't, see study note on Leviticus 4:1–5:13). Some scholars think this offering was only for purification or decontamination, including cases mentioned in Leviticus 5:1–6.

This offering here was part of a purification ceremony. But it is more probable that the sin offering addressed a lack or failure. In this context, the focus is on purity rather than sin. It is meant to restore the woman to community fellowship, not to forgive a sinner.

Leviticus 12:7

make atonement for her: Here "atonement" means ceremonial cleansing and making peace between the worshiper and God (see Leviticus 4:20; also refer to study note on 1:4).

Leviticus 12:8

cannot afford a lamb: The alternative offering is for the poorer members of society (see Leviticus 5:7–13; compare Luke 2:22–24).

Leviticus 13:1–46

a skin disease: The Hebrew word tsara'at refers to more than Hansen's disease (leprosy), which is rare and severely disfiguring. In Leviticus, the word describes many different conditions. These include:

- an open sore (13:10),
- a boil (13:18),
- a burn (13:24),
- a sore on the head or chin (13:29),
- shiny white patches (13:38), or
- unusual baldness (13:40).

A key test was whether the condition spread to other parts of the body (13:5–8). If it did, they quarantined the person while the disorder lasted (13:46). Not only people, but also clothing and even buildings could become infected (13:47–59; 14:33–53).

Leviticus 13:1–14.57

Regarding regulations for infections, the idea of "normal" and "abnormal" is important (see "Clean, Unclean, and Holy" Theme Note). Infections in people, clothing, or buildings are not normal. They indicate disease and death. This is the opposite of wholeness. So, infections make a person ceremonially unclean.

Leviticus 13:2

- Skin disorders that could become contagious required precautions to stop their spread. These included swelling, rashes, or discolored skin. Until healed, the person was ceremonially unclean. The diseases mentioned here had a broad range. These included allergic rash, ringworm, or eczema, as well as serious conditions like gangrene. In Old Testament times, people diagnosed skin conditions by observation. Priests served in religious and medical roles.
- one of his sons: These priestly duties were meant for future generations of priests too.

Leviticus 13:3

deeper than the skin: This means the infection either damaged the skin or was visible under it. The white hair and the skin depression showed a skin disease that could spread (Leviticus 13:21–23). This made the person ceremonially unclean (13:8).

Leviticus 13:4–5

The main purpose of isolating someone was to find out if a person was sick. It gave the priest time to watch the person's symptoms.

Leviticus 13:8

If the rash spread, the priest declared the person unclean, and the isolation became long-term.

Leviticus 13:10

The key factor was the presence of an open sore, because it showed that there was an infection.

Leviticus 13:12–13

The completely white skin might mean a loss of pigment (see also Leviticus 13:3). Raw flesh showed infection and ceremonial uncleanness (13:10, 14).

Leviticus 13:24–25

- The priest needed to check the burned area to see if there was an infection in the wound (see Levticus 13:9–17).
- hair ... has turned white: See 13:18–23.

Leviticus 13:30

The scaly outbreak indicated a fungal infection in the scalp or beard, hidden by hair. Symptoms included hair loss and crusty skin.

Leviticus 13:38–39

If a skin rash had pus or swelling, it was probably an infection (Leviticus 13:42). If it only appeared as a white area, it was probably vitiligo (leucoderma). This harmless condition causes patches of skin to lose color.

Leviticus 13:42

A reddish-white sore may have shown signs of pus (a thick fluid from infection) and swelling.

Leviticus 13:45

- People often tore their clothing, left their hair uncombed, and covered their mouths to show they were mourning (Leviticus 10:6).
- Unclean, unclean!: This cry indicated both social rejection and a health risk. It warned others that the person's skin disorder might be contagious and that holy items should not touch the ceremonially unclean person.

Leviticus 13:46

The tabernacle, which held the ark of the covenant, was at the center of the camp. This was so the people would know God was present there (Deuteronomy 23:14). If someone had a skin disorder, they had to live alone in a place outside the camp. This prevented the spread of infection and kept holy things cermonially clean.

Even Miriam, the sister of Moses and Aaron, spent seven days outside the camp (Numbers 12:15). This area was not just for those with skin disorders. They also burned uneaten sin offerings (Lev 4:21) and executed criminals there (24:14, 23). They took dead bodies there to keep the living area ceremonially clean (10:4–5). People also took care of bodily functions outside the camp (Deuteronomy 23:12–14).

Leviticus 13:47

mildew: This word refers to different types of molds or mildews that could spread on cloth or leather.

Leviticus 13:47–59

In Israel, the rainy season lasts from mid-October through March, bringing humid and cool weather. Mildew thrives during this period. Its spores can cause severe allergic reactions, creating a health issue.

The rules for mildew in clothing were like those for infections in people. If the mildew spread, it was serious. If they could stop, wash, or cut it out, they could save the garment. This process was also similar to treating rot and mold in buildings (Leviticus 14:33–53).

Leviticus 14:1–32

To fully understand these verses about purifying infected people, read them with Leviticus 13:1–46.

Leviticus 14:4

The items listed here were part of the cleansing ceremony with the ashes of the red heifer (Numbers 19:6). Their exact significance is unclear (see also Hebrews 9:18–22). Hyssop was a small plant used for sprinkling blood and in purification rites (Exodus 12:22; Numbers 19:18).

Leviticus 14:5–7

Killing the bird and sprinkling its blood (Leviticus 14:7) is similar to Exodus 24:6–8. This is where Moses sprinkled all of Israel with blood to establish them as God's covenant community. In these verses, they cleansed the individual by sprinkling them with blood and allowed them to return to the community. They also used fresh water in cleansing ceremonies and in preparing sacrifices (Numbers 8:7; Leviticus 1:9, 13).

Leviticus 14:7

The goat released to Azazel symbolized removing sin from the community on the Day of Atonement (Leviticus 16:10, 20–22). In a similar way, releasing the live bird symbolized removing an individual's ceremonial uncleanness.

Leviticus 14:12

The guilt offering was also sometimes called the "penalty" or "reparation" offering. It was for those who were ceremonially unclean and lived outside the camp. They could not bring sacrifices, tithes, and offerings while unclean (see Leviticus 5:14–16).

Leviticus 14:14

the right earlobe ... thumb ... big toe: These symbolized what a person hears, does, and where they go (also Leviticus 14:17, 28; see study note on 8:23).

Leviticus 14:15–17

In the ancient world, people often used olive oil to help with healing (see Isaiah 1:6; Luke 10:34). Its use here might symbolize healing and cleansing of the infection. This allowed the person to rejoin the community. It may also have represented a restored connection between God, the priest, and the worshiper.

Leviticus 14:19

- This sin offering was the purification offering mentioned in Leviticus 12:6 (see 4:2–3).
- burnt offering: This atoned for sins committed during the time of ceremonial uncleanness when the person could not bring offerings (see 1:4).

Leviticus 14:20

grain offering: See study note on Leviticus 2:1–16.

Leviticus 14:21–32

The ceremony for the poor was similar to the usual purification offering. But, it allowed them to use cheaper birds instead of a lamb (see Leviticus 5:7–13).

Leviticus 14:33–53

Rot or mildew contamination made buildings unhealthy or unsafe. People considered these buildings diseased, so they were not whole or ceremonially clean (see study note on Leviticus 11:1–15:33). The inspection and treatment process was similar to the process for mildew in clothing (Leviticus 13:47–59).

Leviticus 14:34

I put a contamination: Biblical language reflects belief in one God who rules over everything. This means God is described as causing or allowing all events. For example, Exodus 21:13 describes an accidental death as something God allowed (see also Deuteronomy 19:4–5).

Leviticus 14:36

When a house was emptied, it showed that the house was not considered unclean until the priest said it was. The owner removed the furniture so that it would not be included in the quarantine period.

Leviticus 14:37

If mildew spread deeper than the wall's surface, it was more serious than mildew only on the surface. A similar idea was used in examining people with skin disease. The priest looked to see if the disease went deeper than the skin (see study note on Leviticus 13:3).

Leviticus 14:54–57

This is a summary statement about many kinds of infections (compare Leviticus 11:46–47).

Leviticus 15:1–33

The idea of normal and abnormal, along with the created order, helps interpret these rules (see "Clean, Unclean, and Holy" Theme Note). Bodily discharges, like infections (see study note on Leviticus 13:1–46), were not considered "normal" because they weakened a person's health. This made the person seem incomplete. Whether male (15:1–18) or female (15:19–33), such a person became unclean.

Leviticus 15:2

bodily discharge (literally a flowing from his flesh): Most scholars think the word flesh refers to sexual organs, suggesting an infection like gonorrhea. Others believe it might mean a discharge of semen or even diarrhea. But a discharge of semen is improbable because it is specifically mentioned in Leviticus 15:16–17 and only requires washing with water. It is clear that this bodily discharge came from "under him" (15:10). It contaminated anything he sat on or lay upon (15:4, 6, 9).

Leviticus 15:13–15

Unlike the man with a skin disease, a man with a bodily discharge could stay at home (see Leviticus 13:46). He did not need the detailed cleansing ceremony described in chapter 14. He only had to wait seven days after the discharge stopped, wash (15:13), and offer two birds as sacrifices. One was a sin offering and the other was a whole burnt offering.

Leviticus 15:16–17

In the case of an emission of semen, the discharge was not a sign of illness (see study note on Leviticus 15:1–33). But the same rule applied. The man had to wash and was ceremonially unclean until the next evening.

Leviticus 15:18

If a man had a seminal emission during sexual intercourse, both he and the woman became unclean. They had to wash and remain unclean until evening. This was because of a natural bodily emission, not because of infection or disease, and no sacrifice was required.

Leviticus 15:19–23

A woman's menstrual period is natural and not a disease. But because it involved a bloody discharge,

she became ceremonially unclean (see Leviticus 15:32–33). The rules were similar to those for a man with a bodily discharge (15:2–12). She could stay at home, but anything she sat on became unclean. Anyone who touched her had to wash, and she probably did the same after the seven-day quarantine. There was no animal sacrifice needed.

Leviticus 15:24

Sexual intercourse with a woman during her menstrual period will later be forbidden and will have a harsh penalty (Leviticus 8:19). This verse probably describes a situation where the woman's menstrual flow went unnoticed when the sexual activity started. Or it could be when her period began during intercourse. The rules required the man who came into contact with her blood to share the woman's seven-day quarantine.

Leviticus 15:25–29

Normal menstruation did not require any offering from the woman (Leviticus 15:19–24). If a woman had a discharge of blood lasting more than seven days, she needed a cleansing ceremony. This was similar to the one for a man cleansed of a bodily discharge (15:13–15; see also Matthew 9:20–22).

Leviticus 15:32–33

This is a summary of the principles in Leviticus 15:1–31. Bodily discharges made a person ceremonially unclean. This included pus, semen, menstrual fluid, or blood.

Leviticus 16:1–34

The day of atonement, on the tenth day of the seventh month, was the most serious and holy day of the year for Israelites (see Leviticus 16:29; 23:27; Numbers 29:7). It was the only required fast and a Sabbath of rest for all the people (Leviticus 23:32). The Feast of Trumpets came before it and announced its arrival (Numbers 29:1, 7–11). On this day, God forgave the sins of the community. Only the high priest, Aaron, could lead the ceremony because he represented all the people. This included Aaron's sons, the other priests. Today, the Jews call the day of atonement Yom Kippur.

Leviticus 16:2

A veil separated the Holy Place from the Most Holy Place. The sanctuary was like God's palace. The Most Holy Place was his throne room, and the ark was his throne (see Leviticus 1:1). In the ancient Near East, entering a king's presence without an invitation could mean death (Esther 4:11).

So, Aaron could not enter the Most Holy Place informally. Even the high priest could not enter. The only exception was when God required his presence for the Day of Atonement ceremony.

Leviticus 16:4

During the Day of Atonement ceremony, the high priest wore simple linen clothes instead of his usual robes. This probably symbolized the humility everyone should have on this solemn day. The high priest stood in front of God as the representative of the people. But he had nothing to boast about for himself or them. But when he stood in front of the people for God, his official robes showed God's glory and splendor (Leviticus 16:23).

Leviticus 16:6

The New Testament writer of the Letter to the Hebrews compares Aaron's work for Israel to Christ's work for believers. Both provided atonement for their people. Aaron had to offer a sacrifice for himself before he could offer a sin offering for the people to ensure God forgave his own sins (Hebrews 5:1–3). But Christ did not sin, though tempted (Hebrews 4:15). So, as the high priest for all Christians, he did not need to make a similar sacrifice (Hebrews 7:26–28).

Leviticus 16:8

scapegoat: The Hebrew term 'aza'zel (Azazel) appears only in Leviticus 16:8, 10, 26. The word has four general interpretations:

1. a term meaning "the goat of going away";
2. a demon that lived in the wilderness;
3. a stronger form of the Hebrew word for "go, leave," meaning "complete loss"; and
4. a rocky cliff over which someone pushed the goat.

Since this goat represented the removal of Israel's sins from the camp, the first interpretation is probably the simplest explanation (16:22).

Leviticus 16:16

The high priest had to purify the Most Holy Place and the rest of the Tent of Meeting. Throughout the year, the sins of the Israelites made the whole sanctuary ceremonially unclean. To keep the Tent of Meeting as a place to encounter God in the coming year, it needed purification. The same was true for the altar (Leviticus 16:18).

Leviticus 16:23–24

For this ceremony, the high priest had to wear special clothing used only for this purpose (Leviticus 16:4). When the ceremony ended, he had to leave the garments in the Most Holy Place. Many scholars believe that bathing and changing clothes were necessary because handling the sin offering caused ceremonial uncleanness.

Leviticus 16:27

On the day of atonement, the high priest brought the blood of the sin offerings into the Most Holy Place. Because of this, they burned the offerings completely instead of eating them (Leviticus 4:3–21).

Leviticus 16:29

- you shall humble yourselves: The Hebrew word is ‘anah, which means “to humble” or “to afflict yourselves.” In practice, this word is closely connected with fasting (Isaiah 58:3, 5).
- foreigner: The Hebrew word is gēr. It refers to people who were not Israelites but lived among them. Foreigners sometimes joined in Israel’s worship (see Numbers 9:14). They probably did not own land but worked as day laborers, share-croppers, or tenant farmers. But if they lived among the Israelites, they had to follow Israelite laws and customs (see, for example, Leviticus 24:16).

Leviticus 16:31

The Israelites considered the day of atonement to be a Sabbath day. No one in the camp, whether Israelite or foreigner, could work (see Leviticus 19:30).

Leviticus 17:1–26.46

This section explains how the people of Israel were to live in holiness. Holiness is not just one quality of God. It describes all that God is—his person, nature, and character (see study note on Exodus 3:5).

God’s “glory” demonstrates his holiness (see Leviticus 9:6). God’s covenant with Israel meant the people and the nation shared in God’s holiness. This holiness relied on Israel’s relationship with God. This relationship required Israel to meet certain ethical and ceremonial standards.

Leviticus 17:3–9

These rules show that unsupervised sacrifices could lead a mixture of pagan practices with true worship of the Lord (see also Deuteronomy 12:15–21; Leviticus 17:7). Israel camped around the Tent of Meeting so it was easy to bring an animal to the sanctuary for slaughter (see also Deuteronomy 12:15–21). Deuteronomy 12:20–24 anticipates Israel settling in the land and the challenges of this rule. It allowed slaughtering and eating meat without bringing it to the sanctuary, as long as they did not consume the blood.

Leviticus 17:4

- that man shall incur bloodguilt: This person unlawfully killed an animal. God gave the animal life, and its blood must return to him through sacrifice.
- cut off: See study note on Leviticus 7:20–21.

Leviticus 17:7

- have prostituted themselves (Hebrew zanah, which means “commit fornication”): Israel must worship only the Lord (Exodus 20:3). Israel’s covenant with the LORD was like a marriage (see Hosea 1:2). Worshiping other gods was like spiritual adultery.

Many Canaanite religions were fertility cults. This verb refers to prostitution at Canaanite pagan worship shrines. They believed these acts would make the land fertile through magic rites involving sexual intercourse.

- The Hebrew word for goat demons is the plural form of “a male goat.” In ancient times, the male goat symbolized fertility or a god of the underworld. During King Jeroboam I’s reign, many Levites from the northern kingdom moved to Jerusalem. The use of goats and bulls in northern worship shocked them (2 Chronicles 11:15–16).

Leviticus 17:11

the life of the flesh is in the blood: God forbade Israel to consume blood because it symbolized the life given by God (Leviticus 17:10). They set it aside as God’s portion of each animal offering. God also designated the sacrificial blood as the way to atone. This means God’s grace accepted the life of the animal in exchange for the life of the sinner.

In the New Testament, the blood of Christ—representing his life freely given—provides eternal redemption for believers (Hebrews 9:12).

Leviticus 17:13

cover it with dirt: This rule stopped hunters from using an animal’s blood for food. Like the blood in altar offerings, the blood of wild game also symbolized life. Uncovered blood was a sign of violent crime. Innocent blood defiled the land (Numbers 35:33). It called out to God for justice (Genesis 4:10; see Job 16:18).

Covering the blood of a killed animal gave it a symbolic burial. This showed respect for both the animal's life and for God, the giver of life. The burial showed that the life was returning to God. This was similar to how the priest poured out the blood at the altar during offerings.

Leviticus 17:15–16

An animal killed by a predator or that died naturally still had blood in its tissues. This made it ceremonially unclean and a possible source of ceremonial uncleanness (Leviticus 22:8). Israelites must throw such an animal to the dogs or give or sell it to a non-Israelite (Exodus 22:31; Deuteronomy 14:21).

If an Israelite ate an animal with undrained blood, he or she became ceremonially unclean. Then they had to wash in water. The uncleanness was not a sin, but ignoring it led to punishment.

Leviticus 18:1–20:27

Chapters 18 and 20 focus mainly on sexual matters. They warn Israel not to follow the practices of pagan peoples, whether in religion or in daily life. Between these chapters, chapter 19 urges the people to live holy lives in everyday situations.

Leviticus 18:2

Many Near Eastern treaties started with the ruler's name and titles. The phrase, "I am the LORD your God," names the great king, Yahweh (LORD), and gives his title, "your God" (see also Exodus 20:2; Deuteronomy 5:6). These words briefly recalled Israel's covenant with God and all it meant. By reminding the people they belonged to the Lord, these words demanded a response (Leviticus 11:44; 18:4–5). Chapter 18 starts and ends with these words, and they appear often throughout chapters 19–26.

Leviticus 18:4–5

- judgments ... statutes: The Bible anticipated that courts would interpret God's laws for different situations. These interpretations became case laws, known as mishpatim in Hebrew (see "statutes" in Leviticus 10:11).
- Paul refers to these verses in Romans 10:5 and Galatians 3:12, where he contrasts living "based on faith" or "by the law."

Leviticus 18:6–7

to have sexual relations (literally to uncover the nakedness of): Similar rules in chapter 20 of Leviticus use the Hebrew word shakab (which means "lie with"). This often indicates an improper sexual relationship.

Leviticus 18:7

- She is your mother: Incest was illegal because it disrupted families. The commands about this sin included close relatives, even if not related by blood. Incest was a serious crime because it caused competition and chaos in the family. It threatened home safety by breaking family intimacy and belonging.
- The Bible directs this command to men, even if the woman was older, like a mother. Men, especially household leaders or firstborns, had more power. This power came with the duty to use it lawfully. Men were more often the sexual aggressors in illegal unions, though not always (for example, Genesis 39:6–18).

Leviticus 18:7–8

expose the nakedness of your father: The Hebrew text equates having sexual relations with your mother or any of your father's wives to having sexual relations with him (compare Genesis 35:22; 49:4; see also 1 Corinthians 5:1). The husband and his wife "become one flesh" (Genesis 2:24; compare Ephesians 5:29). These commands always emphasize honoring your parents (Leviticus 20:9; Exodus 20:12). These commands extend to other family members (see also study note on Leviticus 20:17).

Leviticus 18:9

Sexual relations with a sister from both the same father and mother brought dishonor to both parents. Relations with a sister from only one parent brought dishonor to that parent.

Leviticus 18:12–13

your father's sister ... mother's sister: These actions would dishonor your father or mother.

Leviticus 18:14

Having sexual relations with your aunt would dishonor your uncle. This would also bring dishonor to your father (see Leviticus 20:20).

Leviticus 18:15

Having sexual relations with your father's wife would dishonor your father. Similarly, having sexual relations with your daughter-in-law would dishonor your son. The law considered daughters-in-law the same as natural daughters (Exodus 21:9; compare Genesis 38:1–30).

Leviticus 18:16

Having sexual relations with your sister-in-law would be adulterous and would disgrace your brother. An exception was the law of levirate marriage (see Deuteronomy 25:5–10). This required a man to marry his brother's widow to produce an heir who was considered the dead brother's son.

Leviticus 18:17

Chapter 18 of Leviticus prohibited marrying a woman along with her daughter or granddaughter. This was to prevent family disruption. It would violate the intimacy of the family group by making a wife compete with a younger woman for her husband's love. The penalty for this act was death by burning (20:14).

Leviticus 18:18

The word rival (Hebrew tsarah) clearly describes the relationship between Leah and Rachel as well as Hannah and Peninnah (Genesis 29:16–30:24; 1 Samuel 1:6). In both cases, the wives competed bitterly for their husband's attention.

Leviticus 18:20

- The Hebrew word translated as defile yourself can be more literally translated as to become ceremonially unclean.
- In the Old Testament, sexual intercourse with a neighbor's wife or any married woman was adultery. Breaking this law was punishable by death (Deuteronomy 22:22). Like incest, adultery threatened the integrity and security of the home and family. It violated the marriage covenant and divided the adulterer's affection between his spouse and his mistress.

Leviticus 18:21

- Molech was the national god of the Ammonites (1 Kings 11:7). Later, Israel worshiped this god during times of turning away from their faith (2 Kings 23:10; Jeremiah 32:35). Molech worship probably appears here because it related to sexual sins and possibly included child sacrifice.
- profane (or blaspheme) the name of your God: This meant using the name of the Lord as if it were unholy, such as in a false oath or in the worship of a false god (Leviticus 19:12; Ezekiel 20:39).

Leviticus 18:22

In Genesis 1:31, God declared all things good. This shows that what God creates and the way he designed it to work define what is good. One part of this good creation was the making of woman as a companion for man (Genesis 2:22–24). Marriage reflects this design. It forms a small picture of the whole human race, which together bears God's image. Sin entered the world through the original disobedience of humanity (called "the Fall") and disrupted this order (Genesis 3).

One example of this disruption is homosexuality. In Romans 1:25–32, Paul connects same-sex relations to the rejection of God by humanity that has turned away from him. The Hebrew word to'ebah is often translated as"abomination." This word expresses strong disapproval and disgust (Leviticus 20:13; see also 18:26–30).

Leviticus 18:23

- Like homosexuality, bestiality violates God's created order (see study note on Leviticus 18:22).
- The Hebrew word for perversion refers not only to a violation but also to a confusion of the order God created. It destroys the clear boundaries that God established.

Leviticus 18:24–25

- any of these practices:
- pagan worship (Leviticus 18:21),
- homosexuality (18:22), and
- bestiality (18:23).
- The land could not endure the sinful practices of the Canaanites. It is described as vomiting them out, showing how completely they would be removed (see 18:28).

Leviticus 18:28

Just as the land spewed out the Canaanites, it would also vomit the Israelites if they behaved like the Canaanites (see study note on Leviticus 18:24–25). This happened when the Assyrians destroyed and exiled the northern kingdom in 722 BC (2 Kings 17:6). This also happened when the Babylonians destroyed and exiled Judah in 586 BC (2 Kings 25:8–21).

Leviticus 19:2

Be holy: See study note on Leviticus 11:44–45.

Leviticus 19:3

I am the LORD (see Leviticus 18:2): These words divide chapter 19 into short, strong sections (19:3, 4, 10, 12, 14, 16, 18, 25, 28, 30, 31, 34, 36, 37). Each use reminded Israel why they must obey God's rules.

Leviticus 19:9–10

you are not to reap ... Leave them for the poor and the foreigner: Israel's covenant with God included a social structure that promoted equality and resisted social divisions. Families had to support relatives facing difficulties. Widows and orphans, the poor, and foreigners were part of Israel's extended family (Exodus 22:22; Leviticus 19:10). The poor received special consideration in the offering system and measures ensured they had food to eat (5:7–13).

Leviticus 19:11

A society that does not respect the property of others would quickly collapse. Exodus 20:15 prohibited stealing. Those who deceived or cheated had to present a guilt offering (see Leviticus 6:2–7).

Leviticus 19:12

profane the name: This means to blaspheme (speak in a way that dishonors God; study note on Leviticus 18:21).

Leviticus 19:13

Day laborers did not own land and were among the poorest in Israel. These workers relied on landowners for their income. A hired hand needed to receive his wages promptly to feed his family (Deuteronomy 24:15). This verse considers withholding their wages as cheating them.

Leviticus 19:14

People who could not hear and people who could not see were vulnerable. Others could easily mistreat them. God told the Israelites not to take advantage of them.

Leviticus 19:15

In a legal case, judges were not to favor either the poor or the rich. Justice had to come first at all times (see Exodus 23:3, 6).

Leviticus 19:16

You must not go about spreading slander: Imagine a merchant who trades in damaging rumors and accusations. This behavior quickly weakens the valued community spirit in Israel (see Proverbs 11:13; 16:28; 20:19; 26:20; 2 Corinthians 12:20).

Leviticus 19:17

- your brother in your heart: The Hebrew term can refer to any fellow Israelite. All of Israel was one family (compare 1 John 3:15).
- Directly rebuke: Love does not mean ignoring wrong actions. Correcting someone can help them change.

Leviticus 19:18

love your neighbor as yourself: This is a key principle in biblical ethics found in both the Old and New Testaments (see Matt 22:39; Mark 12:31; Luke 10:27; Romans 13:8–9; Galatians 5:14; James 2:8). It includes loving foreigners (Leviticus 19:34; compare Luke 10:30–37). In contrast, hate can lead to grudges and violence (see 1 John 2:10–11; 4:20).

Leviticus 19:19

two kinds: God created a natural order (Genesis 1:31; see Leviticus 18:22). People violate it when they do not honor God's boundaries. The prohibitions against intermixing served as lessons for the Israelites, who were not to intermarry with the Canaanites.

Leviticus 19:20–22

In the biblical world, betrothal (engagement) was viewed as equal to marriage. Having sexual relations with a betrothed woman who was not a slave brought the same punishment as adultery. The punishment was death (Deuteronomy 22:22; see Leviticus 18:20).

The situation was less clear if the woman was a slave, since she might not be able to refuse. Slaves in Israel had more rights than those in Mesopotamia or Egypt, but they were still not free. They could not punish a slave girl, so the man also went unpunished. Yet, he was guilty in God's eyes and had to sacrifice a ram for his sin.

Leviticus 19:23–25

For the first three years, they should only prune and cultivate a newly planted fruit tree. This helps the tree grow strong. In the fourth year, people considered all of the fruit the "fitrstfruits" and gave the fruit to God (see Exodus 23:16). People could only eat the fruit in the fifth year.

Leviticus 19:26

- blood: See study note on Leviticus 7:22–27.
- Priests could consult the Urim and Thummim (Exodus 28:30). They could also cast lots to decide cases not addressed in the laws Moses gave (Leviticus 16:8). But those who practiced fortune-telling or

witchcraft consulted a power other than the Lord. The first commandment prohibited this (Exodus 20:3).

Leviticus 19:27

do not clip off: Egyptian wall paintings show that Canaanites trimmed their hair and beards carefully. The Israelites were told not to copy this practice so that they would not be influenced by Canaanite religion and ethics.

Leviticus 19:28

cuts in your bodies: Cutting oneself was associated with Canaanite mourning practices (Leviticus 21:5; Deuteronomy 14:1). The word translated as "tattoo" might mean painting the body, a practice also associated with paganism.

Leviticus 19:29

Compare Leviticus 21:9 and Deuteronomy 23:17.

Leviticus 19:30

- My Sabbaths: The Hebrew word for "Sabbath" (shabbath) comes from a verb meaning "to cease," suggesting rest from work.

The Sabbath recalled God's rest on the seventh day after creating the world (Genesis 1:31; 2:1–3). It started at sundown on the sixth day. After the exodus from Egypt, the Sabbath took on covenantal importance (Exodus 16:23–25; 31:13). Only free people, not slaves, had a regular rest day. So the Sabbath symbolized Israel's freedom from slavery in Egypt (see Deuteronomy 5:13–15).

- The people were to have reverence (literally fear) because the sanctuary, like the Sabbath, was holy. They were not to enter it when ceremonially unclean or bring anything unclean into it.

Leviticus 19:31

- mediums: Compare 1 Samuel 28:7–25.
- The Hebrew term for spiritists (yidde'oni) comes from a root meaning "to know." It describes people who claim to have secret or occult knowledge and who try to communicate with the dead.

Leviticus 19:32

In ancient times, people respected the elderly for their wisdom (Job 32:7). Respecting the elderly also shows respect for God.

Leviticus 19:33–34

The Israelites were once foreigners living in Egypt. God commanded them to remember how the Egyptians mistreated them and show love to the foreigners (see Deuteronomy 10:19).

Leviticus 19:35–36

dishonest measures: Merchants sometimes used two sets of weights, one heavy and one light to cheat customers (Deuteronomy 25:13–15). The Bible clearly states that God detested this practice (Proverbs 11:1; 16:11; 20:10, 23; Micah 6:11).

Leviticus 20:2

The people of the land are to stone him: This was the usual method for carrying out the death penalty (see also Leviticus 20:27; 24:14, 16, 23; Exodus 19:13; Numbers 15:35–36; Deuteronomy 17:2–7; Joshua 7:25–26; John 8:1–11).

Leviticus 20:9

The Hebrew word for curses means "to make light of, treat with contempt." It is traditionally translated as "curse," meaning to call someone a vulgar or profane name. Parental authority was given by God, not chosen by the child (see Exodus 20:12; Deuteronomy 21:18–21).

Leviticus 20:9–27

Pagan worship influenced ethics, so God has family rules follow those about pagan religious practices. Some laws in this section repeat parts from Leviticus 18:6–30, which come before the section on proper expressions of holiness (19:1–37). These issues connect. Proper worship of God leads to good behavior toward others, while improper worship leads to moral violations.

Leviticus 20:10

See study note on Leviticus 18:20. See also Exodus 20:14.

Leviticus 20:11

See study note on Leviticus 18:7–8. This rule made it clear that this act was both incest and adultery.

Leviticus 20:17

- a disgrace: Proper behavior brings honor to individuals and their families. Improper behavior brings shame.
- Both parties are cut off, but they will punish the man (see Leviticus 7:20–21; 5:1; 18:6).

Leviticus 20:20–21

Being childless brought public shame in society. People considered it a judgment from God (see Genesis 30:1–2; Deuteronomy 7:14).

What situation do these verses describe? Leviticus 18:14,16 already discuss sexual relations with an uncle's wife or sister-in-law. Deuteronomy 22:22 addresses adultery that results in death for both involved. If the woman was a widow without a male heir, the law of levirate marriage could apply (Deuteronomy 25:5–6; see study note on Leviticus 18:16).

Since those situations do not seem to apply, this law probably refers to marrying an aunt or a sister-in-law after her divorce. John the Baptist apparently used this law to condemn Herod Antipas's marriage to Herodias (see Mark 6:17–29).

Leviticus 20:24

The phrase flowing with milk and honey appears often in Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy. It means that there is plenty of food and it easy to get. This contrasts with Egypt, where everything depended on the flooding of the Nile and irrigation (Deuteronomy 11:9–12).

Leviticus 21:1–4

Touching a dead body made a person ceremonially unclean for seven days. A priest needed to be ready to handle holy things at all times. So, he could not touch a dead body, even if it was a relative's. Otherwise, he might be unable to serve when needed. The only exceptions were his closest relatives, as there might be no one else to bury them.

Leviticus 21:1–22.33

This section, which discusses priestly rules, six times repeats the phrase I am the Lord who sanctifies (Leviticus 21:15, 23; 22:9, 16, 32; see also 21:8). These words emphasize the link between God's holiness and the holiness expected of priests. This extended to all of Israel (see 8:10; 11:44–45; 19:2). The text specifically addresses priests in 21:1–22:16, while including both clergy and common people in 22:17–33.

Leviticus 21:5

- make bald spots ... shave off: The laws warned priests not to shave or trim their hair in certain ways (see study notes on Leviticus 10:6; 19:27).
- make cuts in their bodies: They were also not to cut their bodies (see study note on Leviticus 19:28). Cutting the body was a practice of pagan peoples. Defects disqualified most animals as offerings (Leviticus 22:19–25). A defect also disqualified a priest from serving (see 21:17–23).

For example, a eunuch (a man unable to reproduce) could not serve as a priest because he was not a suitable representative of the people (Deuteronomy 23:1). But his priestly family line allowed him to eat his priestly share (see Leviticus 21:22). On the other hand, if a priest became unclean, he could not serve in ministry or eat the priest's share until he was clean again (22:2–8).

Leviticus 21:6

A priest must never dishonor God by treating his name as unholy.

Leviticus 21:7

The priest had to set a high standard of conduct for Israel in worship. This applied to his personal life and family leadership. He could not have any connections to pagan practices (for example, prostitution, Leviticus 21:9). His family also had to be above question, so divorce was not allowed. Early church leaders followed similar standards (1 Timothy 3:1–13).

Leviticus 21:10–15

- The rules for common priests were more strict than for the high priest, who represented all of Israel, including other priests (Leviticus 21:1–4).
- The priest must always keep his hair neat and not tear his clothing in mourning. This ensured he was always ready to serve. While a common priest could marry a widow, the high priest could only marry a virgin. This ensured that future high priests and common priests from that union would have a clear lineage (Leviticus 21:15).

Leviticus 21:22

He may eat: If a descendant of Aaron had a mutilation or defect, he could not serve as a priest to represent the people (see Leviticus 21:18–20). But his priestly family line still counted. He was allowed to eat the priest's share of the offerings (see 2:3, 10; 6:17–18).

Leviticus 22:2–6

They considered the priest's portions of the sacred offerings "most holy" (see Leviticus 2:3). He had to avoid contact with anything ceremonially unclean (11:1–15:33). So, any descendant of Aaron who was unclean could not eat this food.

Leviticus 22:5

In Leviticus, the Hebrew word sherets always refers to an unclean small animal that swarms on land or in water (Leviticus 5:2; 11:10, 20–21, 23, 29, 31, 41–44).

Leviticus 22:9

die because they profane it (see Leviticus 10:1–3): The temptation to make improper offerings continued throughout Israel's history until after the exile in Babylon (Malachi 1:6–9).

Leviticus 22:11

The only male outside the priest's family who could eat the priest's share was the priest's slave. Without this provision, the slave would have no other food.

Leviticus 22:14–16

Like the rules for the guilt offering, a common person who accidentally ate the priestly portion had to repay 120 percent (see Leviticus 5:14–16). Yet, they did not need to offer a ram in this case.

Leviticus 22:15

An Israelite who ate the "most holy" food meant only for priests as if it were ordinary food would profane it (treat it as unholy).

Leviticus 22:18

People could choose to present a gift instead of a burnt offering (see 1:3).

Leviticus 22:21

A peace offering could be given in different ways:

- as a thanksgiving offering,
- an offering to fulfill a vow, or
- as a voluntary offering (see Leviticus 3:1–17).

Leviticus 22:23

The rules for voluntary offerings were less strict, allowing the use of a deformed animal. But fulfilling a vow still required an animal that was not injured or sick. God would not accept a sacrifice that a person could not eat or that was not a whole animal.

Leviticus 22:27

Keeping a newborn animal with its mother for seven days helped determine the animal's health (see Exodus 22:30).

Leviticus 22:28

on the same day: There are several possible explanations for this command, although none is certain:

1. Senseless slaughtering would leave nothing of the herd;
2. it would be cruel to slaughter the young and the mother at the same time; or
3. it would resemble pagan worship rites, where people cooked the newborn animal in the milk of its slain mother (see Exodus 23:19).

Leviticus 23:2

These appointed festivals included times for eating, resting, and fasting. For more details, see Numbers 28–29.

Leviticus 23:5

- Passover started at sundown on the fourteenth day of the first month, as the new day began (see study note on Leviticus 11:24–25). The Passover feast included a roast lamb, bitter salad greens, and bread without yeast (Exodus 12:8). These foods represented Israel's freedom from Egyptian slavery.
- The first month marked the start of the Jewish calendar as late as Ezra 6:19. The month's earliest name was Abib (which means "spring, fresh grain"; Exodus 13:4; 23:15; 34:18; Deuteronomy 16:1). The name Nisan partly replaced Abib after the exile of Israel to Babylon (Nehemiah 2:1; Esther 3:7).

Leviticus 23:5–8

Passover ... Unleavened Bread: These feasts began on the evening before the exodus from Egypt (see Exodus 12:1–28).

Israel had three major festivals:

1. The Feast of Unleavened Bread, which begins the day after Passover (Deuteronomy 16:16)
2. The Festival of Weeks (Leviticus 23:15–21)
3. The Festival of Tabernacles (23:34–43)

Leviticus 23:6

After Passover came the Feast of Unleavened Bread. During this time, Israel ate bread made without yeast. This bread reminded them of their slavery in Egypt and the quickness of their departure from Egypt (see study note on Leviticus 2:11, Deuteronomy 16:3).

Leviticus 23:10–14

The burned part of each sacrifice stood for the whole offering, and the tithe symbolized that all of a person's

money belonged to God. In a similar way, the first portions of each harvest, or firstfruits, represented the entire harvest and even the land itself as belonging to God (Leviticus 25:23).

During the barley harvest, people offered the first portions as part of the Feast of Unleavened Bread (Leviticus 23:6, 10–12). They offered the first portions of the wheat harvest during "the Feast of Weeks" (23:15–21; Exodus 34:22). These gifts to God acknowledged God's earlier gifts to Israel (see Leviticus 2:1). The entire offering of firstfruits became the property and food of God's representatives, the priests (see 2:14–16).

Leviticus 23:11

The phrase wave it symbolizes offering the grain to the Lord (see study note on Leviticus 7:34).

Leviticus 23:14

The Israelites could not eat from the harvest that day until they acknowledged God's gift by making the appropriate offering.

Leviticus 23:15–21

Israel was to start counting seven full weeks from the first day of the Feast of Unleavened Bread. The fiftieth day marked the start of the Feast of Weeks (harvest). The New Testament calls this "Pentecost," from the Greek word for "fifty."

During this festival, people offered the first portions of the wheat harvest. Each person also had to take three quarts of fine flour and bake two loaves of yeast bread. They then presented these offerings to the priest at the sanctuary. See also study note on Exodus 23:16.

Leviticus 23:18

The drink offerings probably contained two quarts of wine (see Exodus 29:40; Numbers 15:5, 10).

Leviticus 23:24

On the first day of the seventh month: the Israelite calendar divided into two half-years. The first half-year began with the first month, called Nisan (Babylonian name) or Abib (the older agricultural name). The second half-year began with the seventh month, known as Tishri on the modern Jewish calendar. This holiday celebration marked the start of the second half-year.

Leviticus 23:27

The Day of Atonement was the most serious and holy day in the Israelite calendar and the only day of fasting (chapter Leviticus 16). The high priest atoned for the people's collective sin. This gave the theological basis (the main teaching and reason) for the greater atonement made by Jesus Christ (Hebrews 9:11–12).

Leviticus 23:29–30

cut off ... destroy: See study note on Leviticus 7:20–21; compare with Exodus 31:14, 15; 35:2.

Leviticus 23:34–43

During the Feast of Tabernacles, the Israelites lived in temporary shelters for seven days. This celebrated the time they spent in tents during their wilderness wanderings. It also reminded them of God's faithfulness during that period. For a list of sacrifices to be offered each day, see Numbers 29:12–34.

Leviticus 23:39

after you have gathered the produce: The Feast of Tabernacles was also called the Feast of Ingathering because people gathered all the fruit and vegetables that were not yet harvested (Exodus 34:22).

Leviticus 23:43

God did not want the Israelites to ever forget his great acts of redemption for them. They needed to teach each new generation about what God had done (Deuteronomy 4:9; 11:19). Their identity and understanding of themselves and God depended on this knowledge. See Deuteronomy 6:20–24; 26:5–9; Joshua 24:2–13; Psalm 136.

Leviticus 24:5

Traditionally called the "shewbread" in the King James Version, this bread was made of twelve flat loaves. It is also called the "Bread of the Presence." Every Sabbath, the loaves were placed on the table in the Holy Place (see Exodus 25:30 and Exodus 25:23–30). This bread was part of the priest's share of the offerings. David and his men ate this bread while escaping from King Saul (see 1 Samuel 21:1–6 and Matthew 12:1–8).

Leviticus 24:7

The priests burned a portion of this bread as an offering (see 2:2). So they made the bread without yeast ("unleavened"; see 2:11).

Leviticus 24:10–23

A large group of non-Israelites, including other Semitic people and Egyptians, left Egypt with the Israelites (Exodus 12:38). Among them was a man with an Israelite mother and an Egyptian father. A fight broke out between this man and a full-blooded Israelite.

the man who was half-Egyptian verbally cursed the Israelite, using the name of God in a disrespectful manner.

Leviticus 24:11

- blasphemed ... with a curse: In biblical times, a name was more than a title. It represented a person's character, reputation, and origin. God is holy, and he required the Israelites to treat him as holy in all aspects of life (see Leviticus 10:3). God's instructed them to show respect for God's name (Exodus 20:7). Using God's name in a curse showed a sinful attitude toward God (Leviticus 24:15). It was punishable by death (24:13–16).

The Hebrew text in this passage uses two different words for "curse." One refers to a formal type of curse, while the other means a blasphemous or irreverent expression. These terms are used together in 24:15–16 to show the seriousness of the offense.

- the Name: The Hebrew text referes only to "the Name." This wording shows care and respect for God's name.

Leviticus 24:14

Those who heard someone curse against God had to lay their hands on his head. This act showed their innocence by symbolically transferring the guilt (see Leviticus 16:21). It also showed their willingness to take responsibility for the person's death. A single witness was not enough to sentence someone to death (see Numbers 35:30; Deuteronomy 17:2–7; Matthew 18:16; 2 Corinthians 13:1; 1 Timothy 5:19; Hebrews 10:28).

Leviticus 24:17

Because human life was made in the image of God (Genesis 1:26, 27), murder was seen as an attack against God himself. It carried the same penalty as speaking blasphemy against God (Genesis 9:6). For a similar law and its details, see Exodus 21:12–14.

Leviticus 24:20

eye for eye: This legal principle is often called lex talionis (which means "law of retaliation"). This means the punishment should match the crime. When an injured person sought revenge for their family member, excessive revenge often occurred instead of proper justice (see Numbers 35:19–21). This led to even more retaliation, creating a cycle of increasing violence. Lex talionis helped regulate how to prosecute crimes (see also Leviticus 6:2–7; compare Exodus 21:24; Leviticus 24:20; Deuteronomy 19:21; Matthew 5:28–39).

Leviticus 24:22

Foreigners were not citizens, but they were human beings who deserved equal justice under the law (see Leviticus 16:29, 31).

Leviticus 25:1–55

Just as seven days made a week ending in a Sabbath day, every seven years ended with a Sabbath year. After seven Sabbath years, or 49 years, came a special year called the Year of Jubilee. Like so many holy days, these times were meant for reflecting on Israel's shared identity and their relationship with God.

Every Israelite, both free and servant, had a place in God's kingdom. So, those bound in servitude were set free during the Year of Jubilee (Leviticus 25:39–43). To reduce poverty and protect families, land sales were limited to fifty years. After that, the land returned to the original owner's family or clan.

The land belonged to God, and the Israelites were only "residents" (25:23). But it is unlikely that they actually used these laws. The best land ended up belonging to wealthy landowners (Isaiah 5:8–10; compare Amos 5:11).

Leviticus 25:2–7

during the Sabbath year, people did not formally farm or harvest the land. Landowners could gather what naturally grew for their daily household needs. They left any uneaten food for the poor and foreigners (Exodus 23:10–11). What remained provided food for both wild and domestic animals. See also Exodus 21:2; Deuteronomy 15:1–11.

Leviticus 25:4

there shall be a Sabbath of complete rest for the land: The idea of the Sabbath is that God rested, so people must rest also (see study note on Leviticus 19:30). This idea also applies to the land.

Leviticus 25:8–17

- The Year of Jubilee occurred every fiftieth year, releasing people from obligations and slavery. This year was also a Sabbath year, meaning no farming took place.

Some scholars believe the forty-ninth year was both a Sabbath (seventh) and Jubilee (fiftieth) year. Counting fifty years would place the Year of Jubilee right after the seventh Sabbath year, leading to two years without harvests.

- During each Year of Jubilee, the land returned to the original clan or tribe that received it under Joshua (Joshua 13–21).

Land had two purposes:
1. It provided an economic foundation for living.
2. It connected the landowner to ancestors. Through them it connected the land distribution under Joshua and the covenant with Moses.

Returning the land intended to prevent powerful land monopolies that could exclude the poor.

Leviticus 25:10

- proclaim liberty in the land for all its inhabitants: See Leviticus 25:39–43, 47–55.
- return to his property and to his clan: If the original landowner had died, his heirs received the land.

Leviticus 25:11–12

The rules for the Sabbath year also applied to the Year of Jubilee.

Leviticus 25:15–16

the number of years: The law did not allow permanent sale of the land. It belonged to God, and Israel was simply allowed to use it (Leviticus 25:23). If the owner had to give up the land because of financial problems, he could lease it for up to forty-nine years, until the next Jubilee. The price depended on the lease length. At the end of that period, the land returned to the original owner's family.

Leviticus 25:23

it is Mine: Israel did not own the land in an absolute way. Their right to live there depended on the covenant, because God himself gave them the land (Deuteronomy 1:8, 39). From this idea of God's ownership comes the call to care for the land as stewards and to share material resources with others.

Leviticus 25:25

The Hebrew word ga'al means "to restore something to its original or proper state." The noun form of this Hebrew root (go'el) refers to a close relative who will fix what is wrong.

This relative's duties included:

- redeeming a kinsman's property to keep it in the family (see Ruth 4:1–4; Jeremiah 32:6–15);
- searching for the kinsman's murderer and bringing him to justice (Numbers 35:19); and
- marrying his brother's widow to produce a male heir for the estate of the dead brother (Deuteronomy 25:5–10; see Genesis 38:6–30; Ruth 4:9–10).

Leviticus 25:29–31

A house in a village without walls was treated the same as land. The family could buy it back. If they did not, it returned to the seller's family in the Year of Jubilee.

But a house inside a walled town was different. No farmland or pasture was included in the sale of such a house. A house could even be built on the town wall without touching the ground (Josh 2:15). For this reason, the land was not part of the property.

Such a house could not be bought back unless the new owner chose to sell it. It also did not return to the original family in the Year of Jubilee.

Leviticus 25:32–34

The tribe of Levi did not inherit land like other tribes. As the priestly tribe, they lived throughout the land (Deuteronomy 18:1; see Genesis 49:5–7; Numbers 35:1–8; Josh 21:1–42). The Levites could only inherit specific cities and the surrounding pasturelands (Numbers 35:2).

The Levites were an exception to land ownership rules. They carefully protected their small holdings. They could redeem their houses even in walled cities. They could not sell the pasturelands outside their towns.

Leviticus 25:35

destitute: Poor Israelites first asked their family for help (see study note on Leviticus 25:25). Second, they depended on the community. God commanded the people to help the poor instead of taking advantage of them.

Leviticus 25:36–37

The purpose of a loan was to help a poor person financially recover, not to profit from their vulnerability. Israelites could not charge interest on loans to Israelites. But Israelites could charge interest on loans to foreigners (Deuteronomy 23:19–20).

Leviticus 25:38

The mention of the land of Egypt reminded the Israelites that they were once slaves. They needed to help the poor among them because of God's covenant with them. Compare Exodus 20:2 and Deuteronomy 5:6, where God begins his covenant with them.

Leviticus 25:40

- The terms hired worker or temporary resident are used together, showing they were similar in Israel's social and economic life. Both described day laborers who had no land of their own and depended on landowners for work (see Matthew 20:1–16; also see study note on Leviticus 19:13).
- Jubilee: See study note on Leviticus 25:8–17.

Leviticus 25:42

The same Hebrew word means both servants and slaves. The Israelites were God's servants, so they could not be slaves to other people. They could only serve temporarily to pay off a debt.

Leviticus 25:43

God created human beings in his image (Genesis 1:26, 27; Proverbs 14:31; 17:5). Fellow Israelites were in a covenant with God. So, even bondservants must receive respect. God's law includes many rules to protect them (see Exodus 21:20, 26–27). Everyone must treat others in a way that shows reverence for God (see Proverbs 14:31; 17:5; James 2:14–16; 3:9–10).

Leviticus 25:44–46

In Mesopotamia and Egypt, people treated slaves like property. They had no rights or protection. Among the Israelites, people could purchase non-Israelites as slaves. Yet God commanded that they be treated well and not abused. Sometimes a slave was even adopted into a childless family (Genesis 15:2–4).

Slavery continued in New Testament times. However, the Old Testament taught that all people share a common beginning because God created humankind. This belief laid the foundation for the later rejection of slavery.

Slavery began after the first humans sinned. This was the start of power-based relationships replacing those of friendship and communication (see Genesis 3:16).

In the New Testament, Christians promote fellowship and communication by calling themselves "a servant of Christ Jesus"(Romans 1:1; Colossians 4:12; 2 Peter 1:1). In Paul's teachings on "the body of Christ" (1 Corinthians 12:27; Ephesians 4:12), all Christians share a common identity (Galatians 3:28; Colossians 3:11; Philemon 1:16).

Leviticus 25:47–55

An Israelite who sold himself or a family member to a foreigner in Israel could buy himself or the family member back. If he lacked the resources to do so, he remained a slave in the seventh year. He had to wait for release in the Year of Jubilee (compare Exodus 21:2). While serving the foreigner, they must treat the Israelite slave as a hired servant, not as a slave (see Leviticus 25:53). The people of Israel belonged to God. No one could sell them as permanent slaves to anyone else.

Leviticus 26:1

- God instructed Israel not to make idols or carved images to worship (see Exodus 20:4–6). Creating an image to worship would would insult God. It limited God to time and space and replaced the living God with a lifeless object.
- Early in Israel's history, people set up stones as memorials for various events (Genesis 28:18; Exodus 24:4). Yet, pillars and sculpted stones had connections to pagan worship (2 Kings 3:2; 10:26, 27). This was especially true when these stones held the carved image of a god. God clearly allowed for some sculptures (for example, 1 Kings 7:25). The focus here is on objects that the people would worship, thus making them into idols.

Leviticus 26:3

Treaties and covenants had conditions. Israel's blessings depended on the people's obedience to God's terms, to whom they had sworn obedience (Exodus 24:7; Joshua 24:21–22). But the covenant itself was unchangeable (Leviticus 26:44–45; see Romans 11:29). Israel could not cancel it. The people had two choices: obedience, which brought blessings; or rebellion, which brought curses.

Leviticus 26:3–39

These blessings and curses are similar to a key part of ancient Near Eastern treaties between a suzerain (a powerful king) and a vassal (a lesser king). In these treaties, the suzerain king promised to protect the vassal king and his land. In return, the vassal swore loyalty to the suzerain.

Blessings and curses followed, with curses usually being longer (compare Leviticus 26:3–13 with 26:14–39; see also Deuteronomy 27:15–28:68). These treaties often called upon gods as witnesses and enforcers. Yet, in God's covenant with Israel, God was one of the treaty parties, with Israel as the other. Since God could not swear by anyone greater, he swore by himself (see Hebrews 6:13; Genesis 22:16).

Leviticus 26:5

When Israel returned from captivity, God promised such a great harvest that it would last until the time of planting the next crops (see Amos 9:13; Joel 3:18).

Leviticus 26:7

Success in war would come from obeying God's commands (compare Leviticus 26:17, 36–37; Deuteronomy 28:6, 19).

Leviticus 26:9

establish My covenant: The fulfillment is in the "rest" mentioned in Hebrews (Hebrews 3:11–4:11). The promised land was meant to provide security and prosperity, a state of "rest," to the Israelites (Exodus 33:14; Deuteronomy 12:10; 25:19; Joshua 1:13, 15). Israel entered the promised land. But their rebellion prevented them from experiencing the covenant being fulfilled.

Leviticus 26:12

your God ... My people: The covenant bound the two groups to one another, making each belong to the other.

Leviticus 26:13

the bars of your yoke: A yoke is a wooden frame that fits over a slave's shoulders and neck. It is used to carry heavy items like water pails. Compare with Romans 6:16–22.

Leviticus 26:14–39

God punishes his people to change their behavior and restore their relationship with him. He acts like a perfectly righteous and loving parent would with a disobedient child. The punishments, meant to stop rebellious behavior, gradually increase. This gives Israel a chance to repent at any time (Leviticus 26:18–28). Even when Israel faced exile from the land in 722 and 586 BC, God was working to restore them (see, for example, Isaiah 40–66; Jeremiah 29:10; Amos 9:11–15).

Leviticus 26:18

sevenfold: This phrase means many times (see also Leviticus 26:21, 24, 28; Genesis 4:15).

Leviticus 26:19–20

If God does not send rain, the ground will become hard and unproductive.

Leviticus 26:29

Starvation would become so severe in the land that when a child died of hunger, the family might eat the child's body. This was a practice seen among pagan nations (Deuteronomy 28:53–57; see 2 Kings 6:24–31; Lamentations 2:20; compare 2 Kings 3:27).

Leviticus 26:30

- These pagan shrines mentioned here were the well-known high places built on hilltops (see 2 Kings 18:4). These shrines mixed elements from pre-Israelite religions into Israel's worship. They competed with the temple for religious authority.
- incense altars (Hebrew khamman): They used some of these altars in the worship of Baal (2 Chronicles 34:4).

Leviticus 26:34

With the people gone into captivity in a foreign land, there would be no one to work the land. It would at last have the "rest" of lying unworked that the people had denied it (see Leviticus 25:1–7).

Leviticus 26:36–39

Disastrous defeat and captivity later came upon both Israel and Judah (see study notes on Leviticus 18:28; 26:14–39).

Leviticus 26:40–45

The chapter ends with a hopeful message: Even after Israel broke the covenant and faced judgment, reconciliation and restoration were still possible if the people confessed and repented (see study note on Leviticus 4:20). God's grace remained. God did not want to destroy his people; he would restore them if they humbled themselves and repented (see also 2 Chronicles 7:14).

Leviticus 26:41

Physical circumcision of males was the mark of God's covenant with Israel (Genesis 17:9–14; Exodus 4:25–26). Uncircumcised hearts are stubborn hearts that do not love God. The people show this through continual disobedience. God promised to "circumcise" Israel's uncircumcised hearts so the people could love Him (see also Deuteronomy 10:16; 30:6; Jeremiah 4:4; Ezekiel 36:25–27).

Leviticus 26:42

God had begun his covenant with Abraham (then called Abram, Genesis 15:18). God continued it with Isaac and Jacob (Genesis 17:19; Exodus 2:24). Jacob's

twelve sons became the ancestors of Israel's twelve tribes. Israel's freedom from Egypt and settlement in Canaan had its basis in God's promises to their ancestors, not on the Israelites' own virtues (Deuteronomy 9:4–5).

Leviticus 27:1–34

This chapter concludes the book by discussing different types of vows. It ends with a rule for redeeming one's tithes (see also chapter Leviticus 25). At certain times, such as emergencies, a person might vow something to God in exchange for answered prayers (see Jonah 2:9). After God answered the prayer, the person might want to ignore the vow. Scripture requires that people vow carefully and then fulfill them (see Leviticus 5:4; Ecclesiastes 5:4–6). Jesus taught that people should not make oaths often or carelessly (Matthew 5:33–37; 23:16–22).

Leviticus 27:2

The vow to become a Nazirite is also called a special vow (Numbers 6:2). Yet, the vow mentioned here was probably a promise made to God when asking for a specific answer to prayer (see Genesis 28:20–22). During that time, some pagan religions sacrificed infants to their gods, but God prohibited this practice (Leviticus 18:21; 20:2–5; compare Genesis 22:12–13).

Therefore, to make special vow to the Lord meant providing service, not sacrificing a life. Whether an individual made this vow or by someone on their behalf, it required payment to the sanctuary, probably for the person's expenses during their service. See also Numbers 6:1–21; Judges 13:5, 7; 1 Samuel 1:11; Amos 2:11–12; Acts 18:18.

Leviticus 27:3–7

- This section shows how people were ranked socially in ancient Near Eastern cultures. An adult working man had the highest rank, followed by an adult working woman. A boy ranked higher than a girl, and both ranked higher than toddlers. Senior citizens, who were past their prime working age, ranked similarly to boys and girls.
- The amount of fifty shekels was about 570 grams (20 ounces) of silver, which was a lot (see study note on Leviticus 5:15). Comparisons with other writings from that time show that the biblical shekel value was very high and unaffordable for most people.

Leviticus 27:8

Like the offering system (see Leviticus 5:7–13), God's law made special allowance for a poor person who wanted to contribute to the sanctuary. In these cases, the priest decided the amount of silver to include with the pledge.

Leviticus 27:9–10

Once someone promised an acceptable animal and the priest at the sanctuary accepted it for God, the animal became holy and belonged to God.

Leviticus 27:11–13

An unclean animal, not suitable for food or sacrifice, could be bought back by the worshiper for its assessed value plus 20 percent. This rule likely aimed to preserve the sanctity of vows and reduce careless dedications. For the 20 percent additional charge on property, see Leviticus 27:15, 19, 31.

Leviticus 27:14–15

- The Hebrew term translated as consecrates is emphatic and means "declares holy."
- This rule applies only to a house in a walled town. Other houses, whether in unwalled villages or on open land, returned to the owner in the Year of Jubilee (Leviticus 25:29–31). If the owner wanted to redeem it, he had to pay an extra 20 percent. If he did not redeem the house in the first year, it became the property of the sanctuary and priests. They could use it as they wished.

Leviticus 27:16–21

The cost to consecrate a field depended on the years left until the next Year of Jubilee (see Leviticus 25:24–28). If not redeemed, the property became the priests' to use as they wanted. Redeeming a field cost 120 percent of its valuation (see 27:11–13). If a landowner consecrated his field without redeeming it, it did not return to his family in the Year of Jubilee.

Leviticus 27:21

- Year of Jubilee: See Leviticus 25:8–55.
- devoted to the LORD: When someone made a vow to devote something to the Lord, that thing became holy. It could not be bought back or exchanged.

Leviticus 27:25

Each of the gerahs weighed about 0.02 ounces or 0.6 grams.

Leviticus 27:26

no one may consecrate: Every firstborn male, whether human or animal, already belonged to God (Exodus 13:2; 34:19–20). Thus, consecrating a firstborn is unnec-

essary. Priests use the firstborn of animals suitable for food or sacrifice (ceremonially clean animals). You can redeem the firstborn of a ceremonially unclean animal, like a donkey, for 20 percent more than its value. Firstborn humans had to be redeemed (Exodus 13:11–13).

Leviticus 27:28

sets apart (Hebrew kherem): This act of devotion could not be undone. The person, animal, or property devoted in this way became dedicated to the service of the sanctuary as the priest defined.

Leviticus 27:29

set apart for destruction (Hebrew kherem): This is the same Hebrew word used in the previous verse. The context here is the Israelite war to conquer Canaan. God set apart for destruction cities, animals, and people considered holy to other gods.

Leviticus 27:30

One-tenth of the harvest (called the "tithe") belonged to the Lord (Deuteronomy 14:22–26; compare Leviticus 23:10–14). The tribe of Levi, which included priests and Levites, did not receive tribal lands. Instead, they received one-tenth of all produce from landowners (Numbers 18:21–29). They set aside this tithe each year (Deuteronomy 14:22). They took it to the sanctuary, where they ate part of it in a ceremony meal (Deuteronomy 14:23–26).

Every third year, they gave a second tithe locally to the Levites and the poor (Deuteronomy 14:27–29; 26:12; see Amos 4:4 for contrast). The Levites then gave a tithe of what they received to the priests of the tabernacle (Numbers 18:26). They used it for their support and to maintain the sanctuary.

Some interpreters believe there were three tithes:

1. the first for the Levites,
2. the second consumed at the sanctuary, and
3. the third for the poor every third year.

Others think there was one tithe, given at the sanctuary for two years, then locally every third year.

Leviticus 27:31

The penalty to buy back a tithed harvest was the same as the fine for someone who accidentally failed to give a tithe (see Leviticus 5:16).

Leviticus 27:32

Just like the crops from the fields, people also gave a tenth of the flocks and herds to God (Leviticus 27:29–34).

Leviticus 27:34

The book ends the way it began (see Leviticus 1:1). It clearly shows that its message came from God through Moses.